

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · September 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Salt Lake City	75.4
#2	A+	Raleigh	75.1
#3	A+	Cincinnati	75.0
#4	A+	Hartford	70.4
#5	A+	Kansas City	69.3
#6	A	St. Louis	66.0
#7	A	Charlotte	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	C-	Chicago	27.2
#49	C-	Detroit	27.4
#48	C-	Sacramento	27.7
#47	C-	Louisville	27.8
#46	C-	Jacksonville	28.5
#45	C-	Richmond	30.9
#44	C-	Grand Rapids	31.6

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	14 cities
B+ / B / B-	16 cities
C+ / C / C-	20 cities
D	0 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · September 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	75.4	3.5%	+4.6%	+3.2%	+1.1%	57 days
2	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	75.1	3.2%	+3.4%	+2.1%	+0.5%	59 days
3	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	75.0	3.7%	+7.2%	+1.0%	-0.2%	42 days
4	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	70.4	2.7%	+5.2%	+1.9%	+2.8%	36 days
5	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	69.3	3.8%	+7.4%	+0.7%	+0.3%	50 days
6	St. Louis St. Louis	A	66.0	3.8%	+2.8%	+0.5%	+0.5%	45 days
7	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A	63.8	3.7%	+4.1%	+1.4%	-0.7%	61 days
8	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.6	4.0%	+4.8%	+1.7%	+0.8%	73 days
9	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A-	61.7	4.2%	+1.5%	+0.7%	+1.4%	48 days
10	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A-	61.1	3.7%	+4.5%	-0.0%	+1.6%	53 days
11	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	60.3	3.1%	+4.7%	+1.6%	-0.9%	60 days
12	Memphis Memphis	A-	60.2	4.7%	+6.6%	+0.1%	-0.9%	68 days
13	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	60.0	4.6%	+3.4%	+1.3%	+0.8%	58 days
14	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A-	59.6	5.4%	+4.0%	+1.4%	+1.0%	58 days
15	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	57.2	4.7%	+5.8%	+1.1%	+0.2%	75 days
16	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	54.7	4.1%	+0.5%	+1.3%	-0.5%	36 days
17	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B	52.9	4.3%	+1.9%	+1.0%	+0.6%	56 days
18	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	52.3	5.0%	+5.8%	+0.8%	-0.8%	45 days
19	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	52.0	3.2%	+3.0%	-0.1%	+0.9%	59 days
20	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	51.3	4.2%	+4.9%	-0.1%	-0.0%	44 days
21	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	51.2	4.8%	+5.3%	+0.6%	-0.5%	74 days
22	Columbus Columbus	B	50.3	3.2%	+3.3%	+0.0%	-1.4%	44 days
23	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	49.2	5.1%	+1.7%	+1.5%	+0.3%	52 days
24	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	49.1	3.7%	+7.0%	+0.5%	-0.2%	85 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	47.5	4.0%	+5.3%	-2.1%	-2.2%	43 days
26	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	47.4	4.3%	+4.9%	+0.4%	-0.5%	55 days
27	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	47.3	5.0%	+3.5%	+1.8%	-2.2%	53 days
28	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	47.1	3.4%	+0.1%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
29	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	45.7	4.4%	+6.0%	+0.2%	-1.7%	38 days
30	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	45.4	3.5%	+0.6%	+0.7%	-1.1%	59 days
31	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	44.0	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
32	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	43.7	3.9%	+2.9%	+0.3%	+2.9%	51 days
33	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	C+	43.5	4.1%	+1.9%	+0.3%	-1.7%	57 days
34	Fresno Fresno	C+	42.9	7.7%	+5.1%	+2.5%	-1.4%	57 days
35	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	42.3	3.9%	+5.5%	-0.7%	-0.9%	40 days
36	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	42.1	4.8%	+2.6%	+1.2%	-2.7%	67 days
37	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.5	4.7%	+2.2%	+0.8%	+0.1%	68 days
38	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	39.4	4.9%	+5.3%	-1.4%	-0.6%	61 days
39	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	39.4	3.8%	+1.5%	-0.1%	+0.8%	36 days
40	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C	37.5	4.7%	+6.7%	+0.5%	-1.8%	45 days
41	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.2	5.7%	+6.0%	+0.8%	-1.8%	63 days
42	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	35.4	4.4%	-0.1%	+1.4%	-1.3%	39 days
43	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C-	31.6	3.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	-1.0%	51 days
44	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	31.6	4.3%	+1.8%	+0.5%	-7.5%	38 days
45	Richmond Richmond	C-	30.9	3.8%	+2.5%	-0.8%	-0.9%	44 days
46	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	28.5	4.9%	+0.4%	+0.4%	-0.3%	65 days
47	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	27.8	4.8%	+1.6%	-0.1%	+0.2%	44 days
48	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	27.7	5.0%	+1.1%	+0.3%	-1.9%	50 days
49	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	27.4	6.0%	+0.6%	+0.2%	+0.7%	40 days
50	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	27.2	4.9%	+3.1%	+0.2%	-2.5%	36 days

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

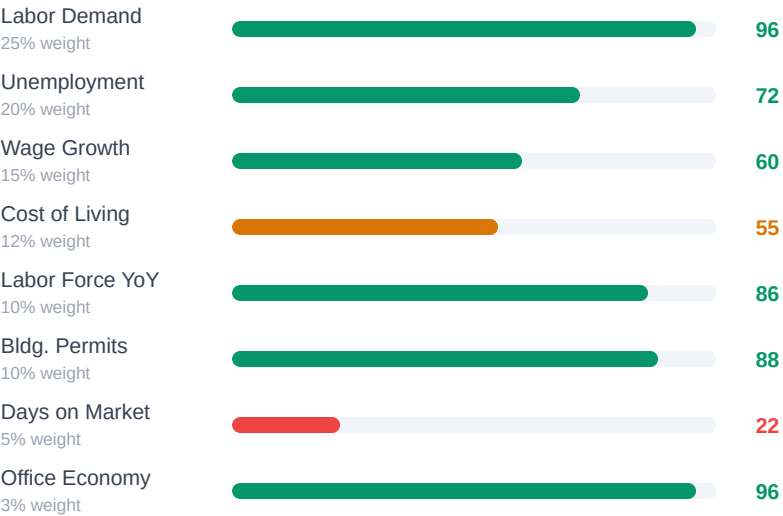
A+

EXCELLENT

75.4th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 75.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 96th percentile, and its strong office economy, also ranking in the 96th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 3.20% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 3.20% employment growth rate and a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend. This indicates that the labor market is experiencing real growth, rather than just absorbing existing workload. The labor demand composite score of 7.70 further supports this interpretation, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.50%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.60%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not excessively so, and that workers are experiencing some increase in purchasing power. However, the wage growth is not exceptionally high, which may help keep labor costs in check.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 55th, Salt Lake City-Murray is near the median in terms of affordability, with a PSF of \$263/sqft and an hourly earnings rate of \$39.49, resulting in a ratio of 6.66. This means that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent. However, the slight increase in PSF of 0.8% year-over-year may indicate some upward pressure on costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is growing at a rate of 1.13% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that businesses will have a larger pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 40.08% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This growth suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers, as the increased supply of housing will help meet demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decrease in days on market suggests that the market may be normalizing slightly.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 96th, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep and talented pool of professional workers, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which may require a different type of workforce.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a growing workforce supply, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the relatively tight labor market and moderate wage growth may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and staff operations, and decision-makers should factor in the potential need for competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

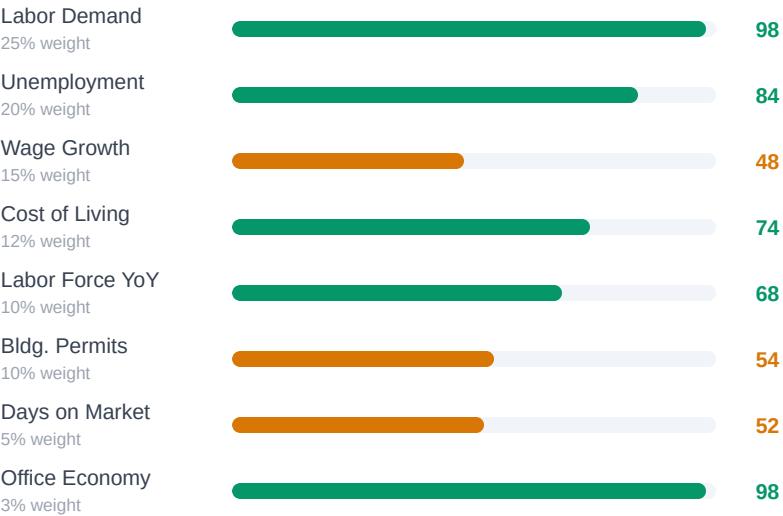
A+

EXCELLENT

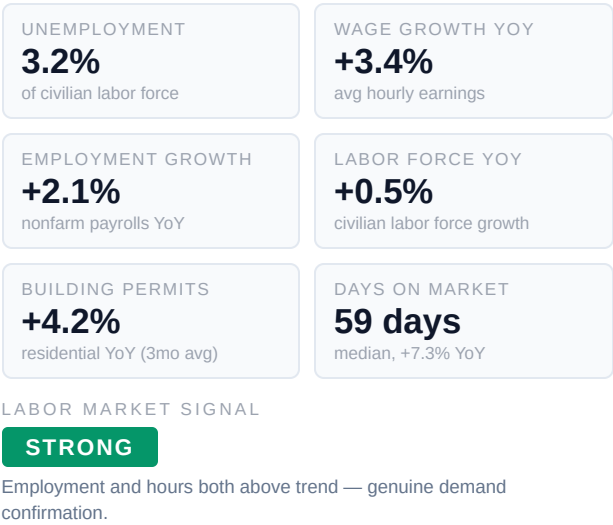
75.1th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 75.1th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 98th percentile, and its strong office economy, also in the 98th percentile, with 4.48 out of 5 score for professional and office worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 2.07% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.137% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area exhibits a strong labor demand, with a 2.07% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.137% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a significant increase in job creation and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 8.33 places it in the top tier, with a 98th percentile rank.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.20%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. With an 84th percentile rank, the city's low unemployment rate suggests a strong economy with limited slack in the labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.43%, which is near the median compared to other US metros. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace. Workers in the area are also experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that places it in the 74th percentile, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's PSF of \$215/sqft is decreasing at a rate of -2.3% year-over-year, relative to average hourly earnings of \$37.64/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.71. This affordability makes it an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.48% year-over-year, which is above average compared to other US metros. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find and hire talent. With a 68th percentile rank, the city's labor force growth is a positive indicator for hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary is increasing at a rate of 4.15% year-over-year, which is near the median compared to other US metros. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing developer confidence and investment in new residential construction, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.3%. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell. With a 52nd percentile rank, the city's days on market is near the median, indicating a relatively balanced market that is neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share score of 4.48 out of 5, placing it in the 98th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. The city is less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain talent, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering a location in Raleigh-Cary.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

75.0th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		48
25% weight		
Unemployment		94
20% weight		
Wage Growth		96
15% weight		
Cost of Living		88
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		54
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		76
10% weight		
Days on Market		98
5% weight		
Office Economy		44
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +24.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 42 days median, +13.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 75.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.70% and strong wage growth of +7.22% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses seeking a skilled workforce, but may also pose challenges for hiring and talent retention.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.97% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.372% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.29, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with slightly below-trend hours. This suggests that businesses can expect a steady, but not explosive, growth in labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.70%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with minimal slack. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring and retaining talent, as the pool of available workers is limited, leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

Cincinnati's year-over-year wage growth is +7.22%, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees can expect higher earnings and increased disposable income. However, this also means that businesses will need to budget for higher labor costs, potentially impacting their bottom line.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF of \$191/sqft and a ratio of 5.37 to average hourly earnings of \$35.56, ranking at the 88th percentile. This means that the city offers a talent attraction advantage, as workers can enjoy a relatively low cost of living without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This suggests that the city's workforce supply is not expanding rapidly, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business growth. Companies may need to invest in talent development and retention strategies to mitigate this risk.

Building Permits

Cincinnati's residential building permits are increasing by +24.76% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 76th percentile, indicating an expansion of future housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city's housing market is likely to become more affordable, which will improve the attractiveness of the city for relocating workers and support workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.5%, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. This means that workers relocating to the city may find it relatively accessible to purchase or rent a home, as the market is not extremely competitive. However, this also suggests that the city's housing market may be normalizing, rather than experiencing rapid growth.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share is 2.28, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not be the best fit for companies requiring a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance firms.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies seeking a skilled workforce. However, the city's slightly contracting labor pool and moderate talent pool depth pose risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Cincinnati as a potential business location.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

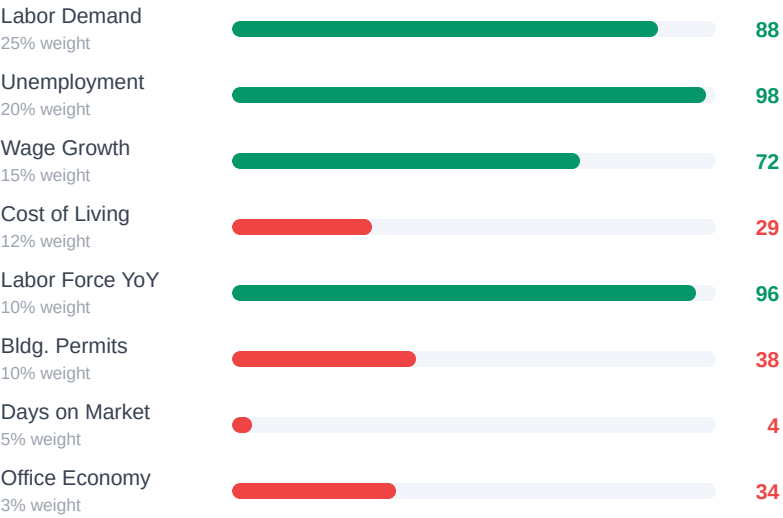
A+

EXCELLENT

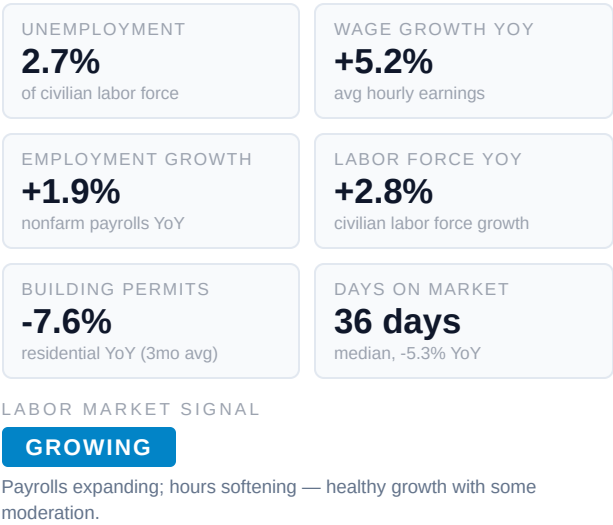
70.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 88th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile. The combination of these two metrics signals a highly competitive job market with strong demand for labor.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.321%, still indicating a strong labor demand. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, albeit slightly below the baseline. This suggests that businesses are hiring and workers are in high demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that there is very little slack in the market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +5.21%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living percentile rank of 29th, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$251/sqft to \$39.67/hr, or 6.33. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering competitive salaries to attract and retain top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding labor force supply. This means that the city has a strong pipeline of potential employees, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by -7.56% year-over-year, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.3%, ranking in the 4th percentile. This indicates a highly competitive market where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other incentives to help attract talent to the area.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has an office economy percentile rank of 34th, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This means that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, it may be less suitable for businesses that require a large number of professional or office workers, such as tech or finance companies.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong demand for labor, a growing labor force, and moderate to fast wage growth. However, the city's high cost of living and tightening housing supply may pose significant challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

Kansas City

Kansas City

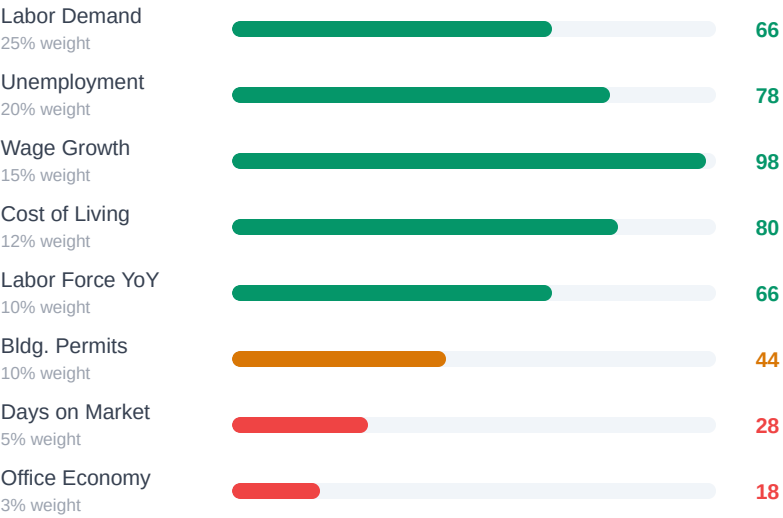
A+

EXCELLENT

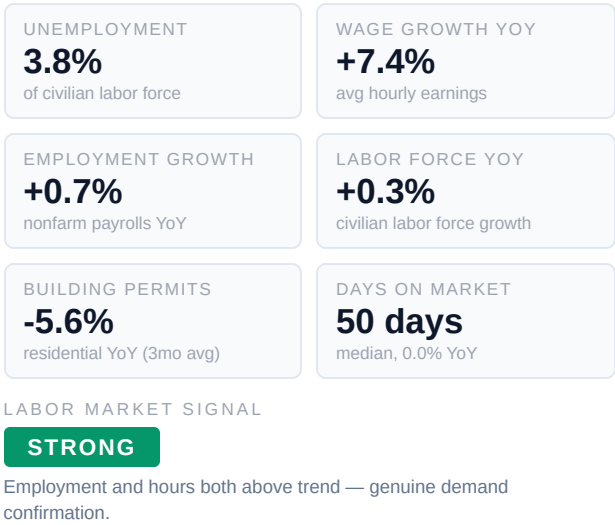
69.3th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 69.3th percentile, ranking it among the top metros in the US. The city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.38%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.80%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor demand and a competitive job market.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of 0.69% and weekly hours deviation of 0.321% above its own trend indicate genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing. This combination signals a healthy labor market with growing opportunities. The labor demand composite score of 5.59, ranking in the 66th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.80% ranks in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.38%, Kansas City experiences fast wage growth, ranking in the 98th percentile. This rapid growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers, which can benefit local businesses.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$196/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.42, ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force growth rate of 0.34% indicates a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is modest, it suggests that the labor pool is not contracting, providing a relatively stable hiring environment for businesses.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits of -5.58% signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This decline in permits, ranking in the 44th percentile, is a notable risk factor for businesses considering relocation.

Days on Market

With a median days on market of 50 days and a year-over-year change of 0.0%, Kansas City's housing market is relatively competitive, but not extremely fast-paced. This balance suggests that relocating workers may face some competition, but the market is not overly inaccessible.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is better suited for businesses outside of the tech, finance, or consulting industries, and may not be the ideal location for companies requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and rapid wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies willing to invest in their workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

St. Louis

St. Louis

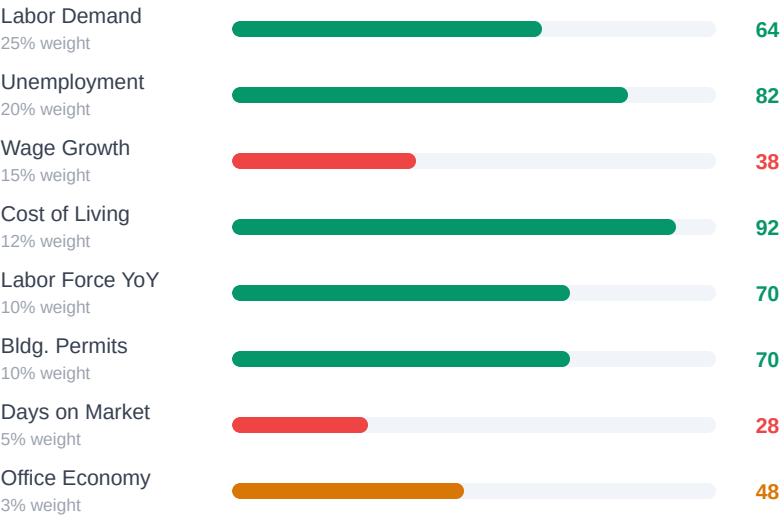
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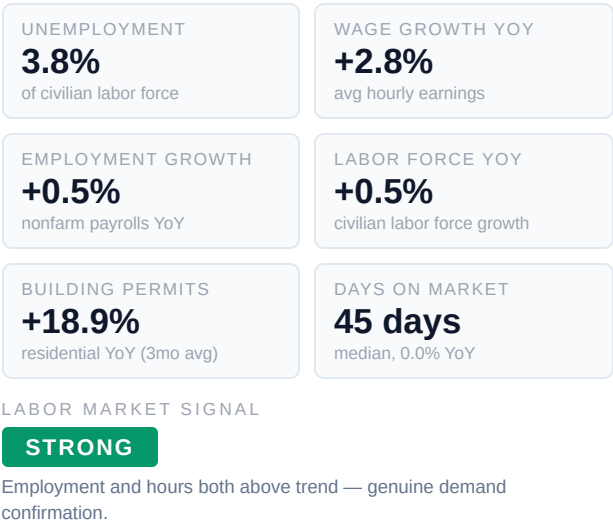
66.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.58, combining a +0.49% employment growth rate and a +0.598% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier cost of living percentile rank of 92, makes St. Louis an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Demand

St. Louis exhibits a +0.49% employment growth rate and a +0.598% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than typical, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.58 further reinforces this, placing the city above average in the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis stands at 3.80%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, which means the market is tight. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a strong local economy with high demand for labor.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in St. Louis is +2.84% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising too rapidly, but it also indicates that workers may not have strong bargaining power. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively stable cost environment, but workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$164/sqft to \$37.84/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.2% in PSF, St. Louis ranks in the top tier for affordability at the 92nd percentile. This high affordability ranking means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage without the need for wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.54% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to staff up or relocate.

Building Permits

St. Louis has seen an +18.86% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in St. Louis currently sit on the market for a median of 45 days, with no year-over-year change. This stable and relatively fast market means that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when searching for housing, which could be a consideration for businesses looking to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share that places it near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that while the city has a decent talent pool for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, it is not as deep as in other metros. The city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with both professional and industrial components.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the tight labor market, which may lead to challenges in hiring and upward pressure on wages, potentially affecting operational costs and competitiveness.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

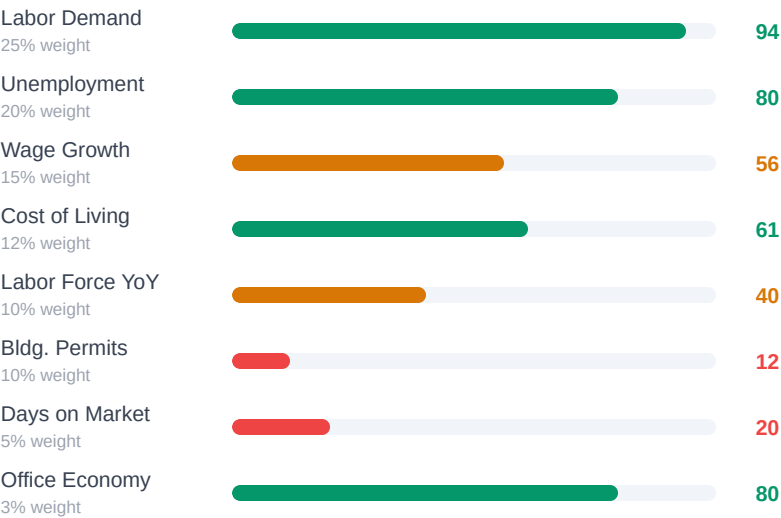
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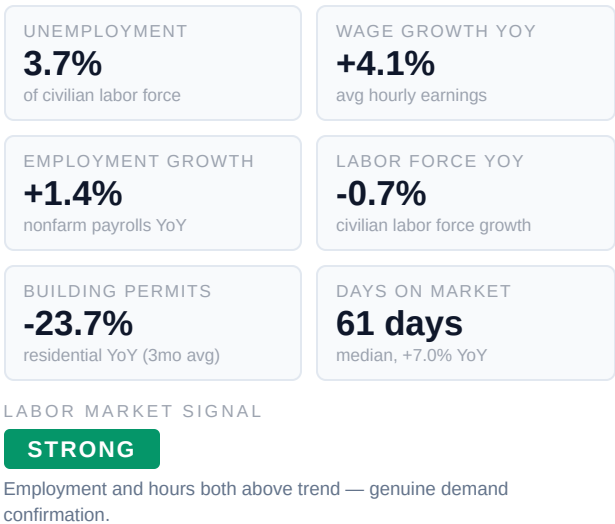
63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 94th and 80th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 7.35, driven by a 1.36% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.141% deviation in weekly hours above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a robust job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.36% and weekly hours deviation of 1.141% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs at a faster rate than the national average, and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a high level of economic activity. The labor demand composite score of 7.35, at the 94th percentile, reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.14% is moderate, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating that labor costs are rising, but not excessively so. This rate suggests that workers are seeing some increase in their purchasing power, but employers are not facing extreme pressure on labor costs. The moderate wage growth rate may help attract and retain workers.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia, with a PSF of \$218/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$37.80/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.77, ranks in the 61st percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.9% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming even more affordable, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -0.70%, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. The negative growth rate may limit the city's ability to accommodate growing businesses.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -23.67%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing market may be tightening, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in attracting and retaining workers. The low ranking in building permits signals a potential risk for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.0%, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. This means that homes are taking longer to sell, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, the slow market may also suggest some softening in demand.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.36, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses seeking specialized talent.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and business expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This risk should be carefully considered by decision-makers evaluating the city as a potential business location.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

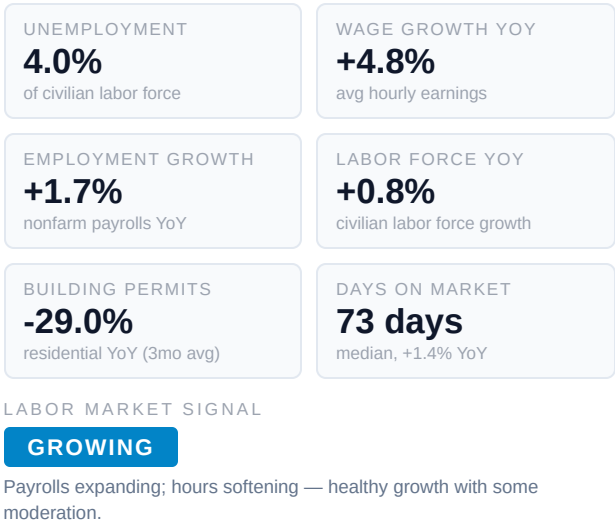
62.6th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 62.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 84th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the top tier at the 90th percentile with a PSF to earnings ratio of 6.15. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 1.70% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.262%, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing job growth with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting that the labor market is absorbing new jobs without overburdening existing workers. The labor demand composite score of 6.42 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 4.00%, ranking in the near median at the 44th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor overly loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may be manageable without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 4.80%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, implying rising labor costs for employers. However, it also indicates good worker purchasing power, which can contribute to a healthy local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a cost of living ranked in the top tier at the 90th percentile, with a PSF of \$231/sqft that has decreased by 8.0% year-over-year relative to hourly earnings of \$37.54. This makes the city more affordable compared to its peers, which is a significant advantage for talent attraction without needing wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 0.80% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for hiring capacity. Businesses can expect a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is -29.04%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This significant decrease in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 73 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.4%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the relatively low percentile rank of 16th suggests that the market might still be competitive.

Office Economy

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranked in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and highly affordable living costs, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and business growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

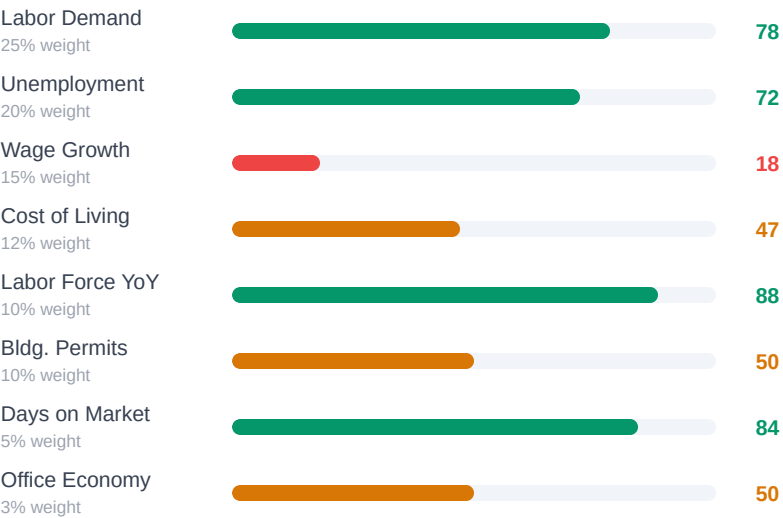
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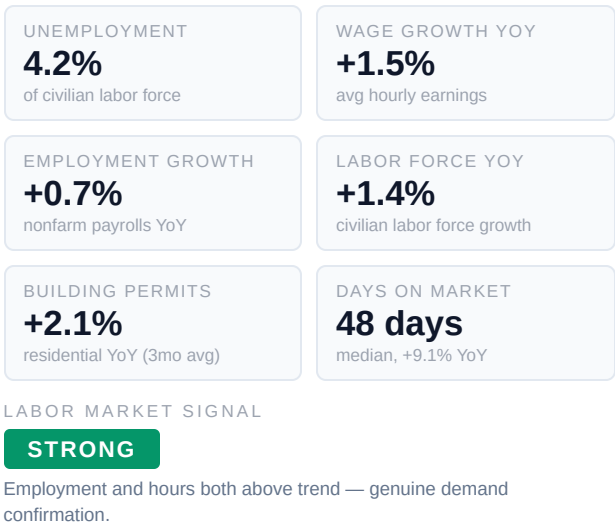
61.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is expanding at a rate of 1.42% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce and increasing job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has seen employment growth of 0.74% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of 0.922% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in job creation and workers are putting in more hours, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 6.26 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 78th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.20%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. With an unemployment rate ranking in the 72nd percentile, the market has some slack, but not enough to make hiring significantly easier.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 1.51%, which is relatively slow and ranks in the 18th percentile. This slow wage growth may help keep labor costs under control for employers, but it also means that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not need to worry about rapidly rising labor costs, but may still need to offer competitive wages to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score ranking in the 47th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$228/sqft to \$32.62/hr, or 6.99. The fact that the PSF is falling by 0.9% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of 1.42% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire and expand. This expanding labor force supply means that businesses will have a larger pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to find and hire qualified talent. With a labor force growth rate ranking in the 88th percentile, the city is well-positioned to support business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has increased by 2.10% year-over-year, which is a relatively modest growth rate ranking in the 50th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, but not rapidly, which may help to keep affordability relatively stable. As a result, businesses can expect that their workers will have a relatively stable and affordable housing market, which can be an attractive feature for talent relocation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is currently 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.1%. This ranks in the 84th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can make it easier to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a professional and office worker share of 2.52, which ranks in the 50th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may not be as well-suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a growing workforce, increasing job opportunities, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tight labor market, which may make it challenging to find and hire qualified workers. Despite this, the city's strong labor demand and expanding labor force supply make it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

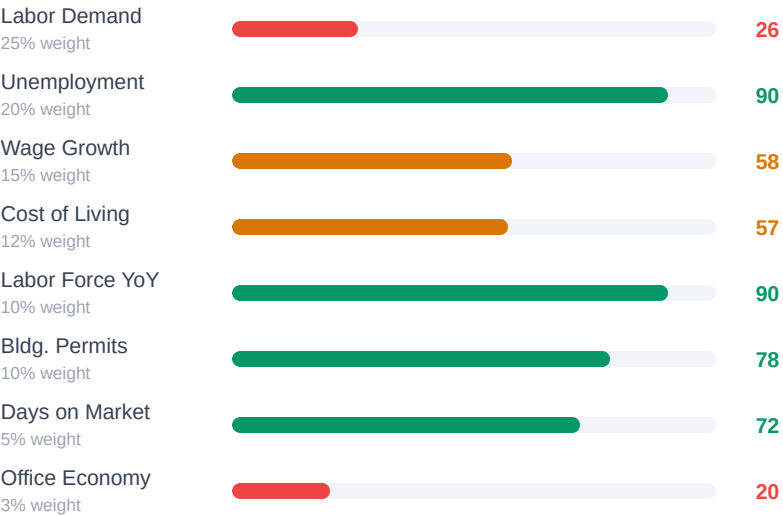
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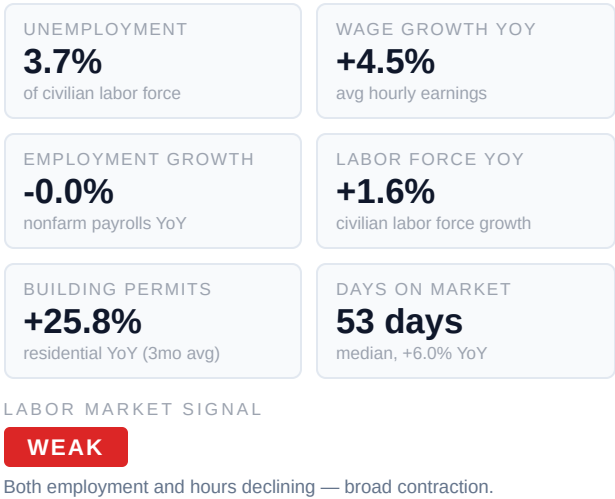
61.1th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.70% and its labor force growth rate of +1.61% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with an expanding workforce. These metrics suggest a city with a strong foundation for businesses looking to hire and grow.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.02% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.470% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.27, which ranks below average at the 26th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates that the city is not adding jobs at a significant pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.70%, ranking it at the 90th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate suggests that there is little slack in the labor market, making it challenging for companies to find and hire the workers they need.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +4.48% YoY, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers in the city are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh has a cost of living score that ranks at the 57th percentile, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.21/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.18. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, although not exceptionally so. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) suggests that the city's affordability is not improving or deteriorating significantly. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.61% YoY, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses in the city will have access to a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and staff their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh is increasing by +25.84% YoY, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This growth in permits suggests that the city's housing market is likely to become more affordable in the future, which can help attract and retain workers. The increasing supply of housing can also help to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 53 days, with a YoY increase of +6.0%. This indicates that the housing market is slowing down slightly, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The relatively moderate days on market suggests that workers will not face extreme competition for housing, although the market is still relatively fast-paced.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy is ranked at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is not as well-suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's slow employment growth rate and limited office economy talent pool are significant risks that decision-makers should factor into their location decisions, as they may limit the city's ability to support certain types of businesses or industries.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A-

GOOD

60.3th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		92
Wage Growth 15% weight		62
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		30
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -21.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 60 days median, +1.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score of 60.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and its above-average labor demand composite score of 6.06, which signals genuine demand expansion. Specifically, the combination of a 1.56% employment growth rate and a -0.424% weekly hours deviation from trend indicates a strong job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Nashville is 1.56% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.424% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 6.06. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. The labor market is experiencing a moderate expansion, with new jobs being added and hours worked remaining relatively stable.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville is 3.10%, which is in the top tier at the 92th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive job market.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Nashville is 4.66% year-over-year, which is above average at the 62th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, indicating rising labor costs for employers. However, it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Nashville has a cost of living score at the 51th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$259/sqft to \$35.38/hr, or 7.32. The city's cost of living is near the median, neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive. With the price per square foot falling -1.1% year-over-year, the city remains relatively competitive for talent attraction without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of -0.95% year-over-year, which is below average at the 30th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Nashville has decreased by 21.89% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges in accommodating a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for relocating workers as it provides them with more time to find suitable housing. However, the relatively low days on market still suggests a competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Nashville has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score in the top tier at the 88th percentile. The city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based economies.

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and above-average labor demand, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Memphis

Memphis

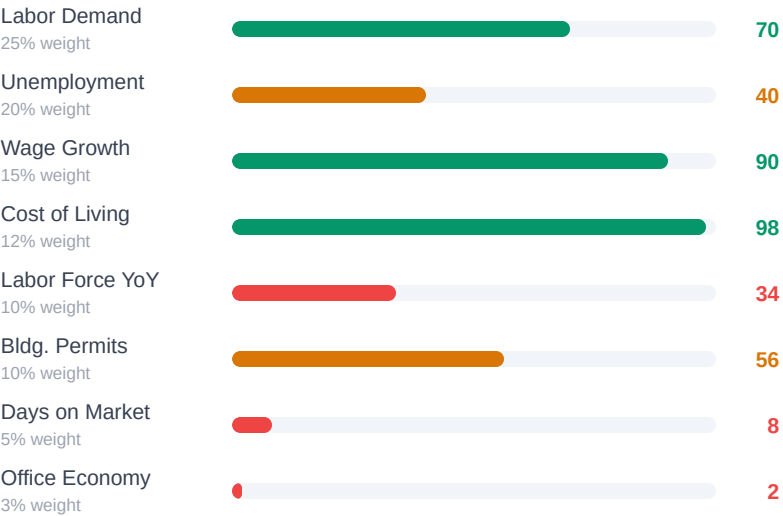
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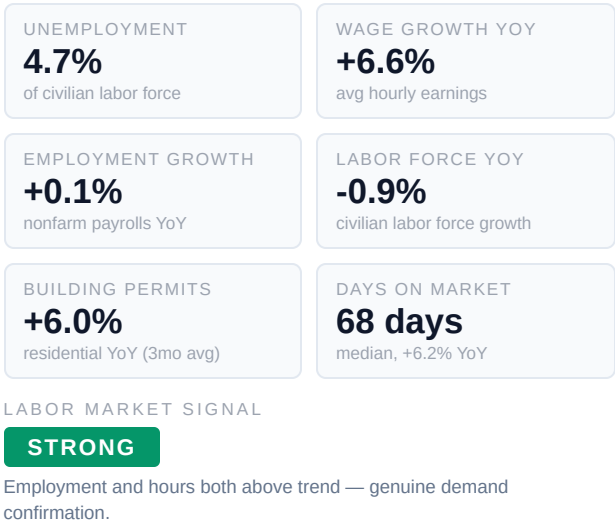
60.2th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth and highly affordable cost of living, with a cost of living ratio of 4.67, driven by a PSF of \$153/sqft that is decreasing by 4.4% YoY, paired with an hourly wage of \$32.74. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and attractive affordability.

Labor Demand

Memphis exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.81, driven by employment growth of 0.06% YoY and weekly hours 1.422% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing organic growth rather than a survivor squeeze. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the city.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.70%, placing it near the median among its peers at the 40th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it's not so high as to indicate significant weakness in local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.63%, Memphis is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses reliant on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Memphis is highly affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank of 98th, driven by its decreasing PSF and favorable ratio of \$153/sqft to \$32.74/hr. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit and retain workers without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -0.92% YoY, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient skilled workers to meet their needs.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Memphis are increasing by 5.95% YoY, suggesting that housing supply is expanding. This expansion is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it indicates that the city is likely to maintain or improve its affordability over time.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis are currently sitting on the market for 68 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.2%. This longer days on market metric, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, suggests a slower, more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to Memphis, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranked at the 2nd percentile, Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that require deep knowledge-economy talent pools, but it may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, highly affordable cost of living, and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for certain types of operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor force supply, which could pose significant challenges for hiring and workforce expansion plans.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A-

GOOD

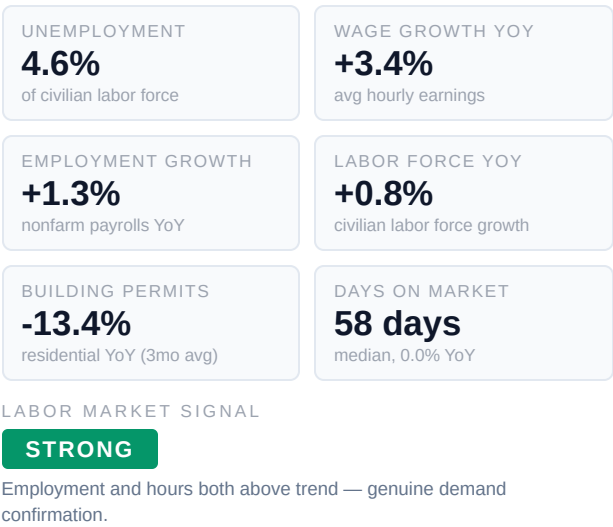
60.0th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 86th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 94th percentile. This combination signals a city with genuine demand expansion and a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.26% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.463% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.53 further reinforces this trend, placing the city in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.60%, which ranks at the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average level of slack in the labor market. This means that the market is relatively tight, making it harder for businesses to hire, and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is +3.44%, which ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and that workers have some, but not exceptional, bargaining power. As a result, businesses can expect to see some upward pressure on labor costs, but it is not likely to be a major constraint.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, with a percentile rank of 94, driven by a PSF of \$199/sqft that is falling by -2.0% year-over-year, and an hourly earnings rate of \$38.32. This means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums. The ratio of PSF to earnings is 5.19, further reinforcing the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of +0.79% year-over-year, which ranks above average at the 76th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees to

hire from. As a result, businesses can expect to have a relatively easy time finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is falling by -13.44% year-over-year, which ranks below average at the 24th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability concerns and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other incentives to attract top talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 58 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the market is competitive, and workers relocating to the city may face challenges in finding affordable housing. However, the lack of change in days on market suggests that the market is not becoming significantly more competitive, which could be a positive sign for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.18, which ranks at the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of workers in these sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. As a result, businesses in these sectors can expect to find a highly qualified and talented workforce in the city.

In conclusion, the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy, with a talented and expanding workforce, and a highly affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability concerns and make it more difficult to attract and retain top talent.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

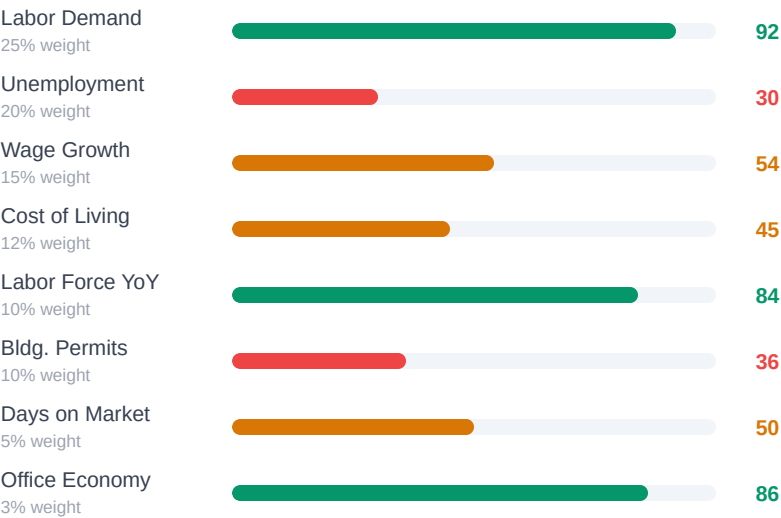
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GOOD

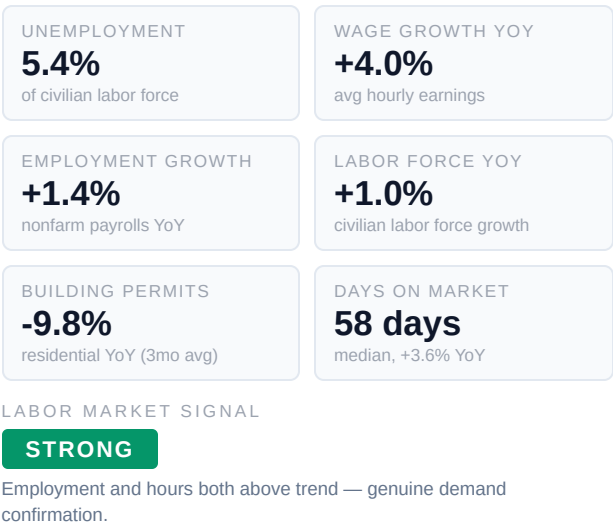
59.6th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, and its moderate cost of living, ranked near the median at the 45th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$261/sqft to \$32.65/hr. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.42% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of +0.733% from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, with more jobs being added and existing workers putting in more hours. The top-tier composite score of 7.02 further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.40%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the unemployment rate is not so low that it would drive up wages significantly due to intense competition for workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is +3.95%, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 45th, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is considered near the median in terms of affordability, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$261/sqft to \$32.65/hr. The fact that the PSF is decreasing by -1.9% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of +0.98% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which can support hiring needs and business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -9.84%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be more accessible for relocating workers, giving them more time to find suitable housing without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas ranks in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. This makes the city an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses but less ideal for those requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a moderate cost of living, making it attractive for talent without excessive wage pressure. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the decline in building permits, which may lead to future housing affordability issues and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

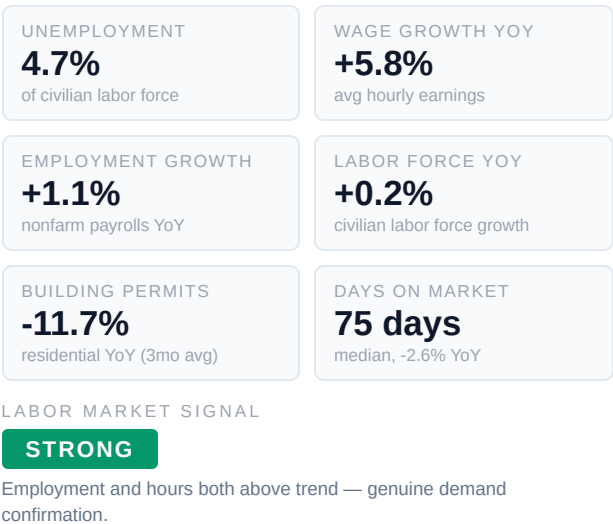
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.2th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 74th percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, at 82nd percentile with a 5.78% year-over-year increase. These metrics suggest a city with genuine job market expansion and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 1.11% year-over-year and a 0.294% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.15 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.70%, ranking it in the 12th percentile, which means the market has some slack. However, for a business trying to hire, this still means that while it may be easier to find candidates, the pool of available workers is not as large as in cities with higher unemployment rates. This could lead to some wage pressure, but not as intense as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.78%, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the 82nd percentile. This implies rising labor costs for employers but also increasing purchasing power for workers, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand. The rapid wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where employers must offer higher compensation to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score that places it in the 78th percentile, with a PSF of \$223/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.52, resulting in a ratio of 6.65. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 2.6% year-over-year makes the city more affordable relative to its peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has grown by 0.22% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is positive, its slow pace may pose a structural headwind for hiring, especially in a market with strong labor demand. Businesses may need to invest more in talent development or recruitment to meet their labor needs.

Building Permits

The city has seen a year-over-year decrease in building permits of 11.73%, ranking it in the 28th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend could erode the city's attractiveness for relocating workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

Homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford are currently sitting on the market for a median of 75 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 64th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, it also indicates a healthy and active real estate market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score ranking it in the 90th percentile, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it particularly attractive for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining housing supply indicated by the sharp drop in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

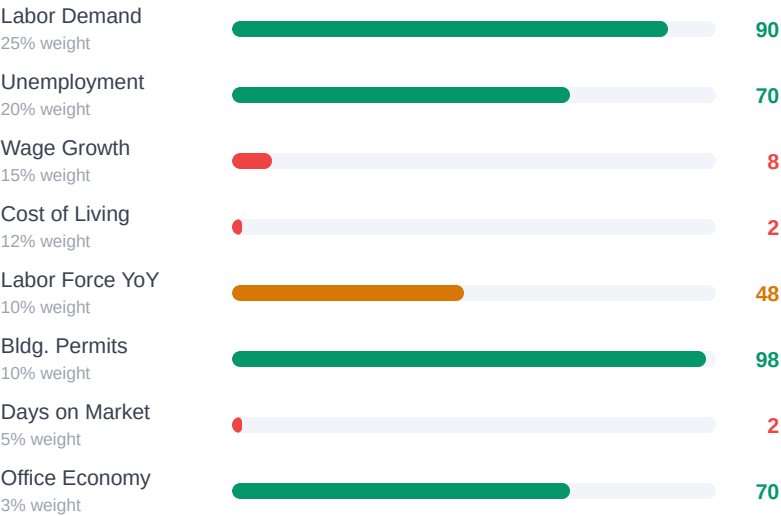
B

AVERAGE

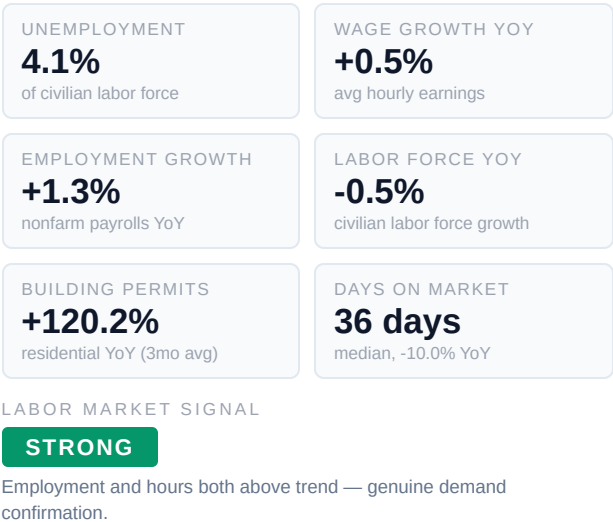
54.7th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and building permits growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.01, combining a 1.34% employment growth rate and a 0.839% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate and cost of living metrics also play a significant role in defining the city's economic character, with an unemployment rate of 4.10% and a cost of living ratio of 15.08.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.01, driven by a 1.34% employment growth rate and a 0.839% weekly hours deviation above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This suggests a strong and growing economy, with businesses likely to face competition for talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 4.10%, ranking in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available to fill open positions. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.51%, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth may help keep labor costs under control for employers, but it also means that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not need to worry about rapidly rising labor costs, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living ratio of 15.08, with a price per square foot of \$811 and average hourly earnings of \$53.77, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. However, the price per square foot is falling by 1.3% year-over-year, which may help improve affordability in the future. This high cost of living may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is higher than in many other cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is growing at a rate of -0.48% year-over-year, ranking near the median, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is not expanding as quickly as demand, which may lead to hiring challenges and upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to be strategic in their hiring efforts and consider offering competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 120.21% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city is investing in its future and preparing for an influx of new residents and workers. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the future, as the housing market becomes more affordable and accessible.

Days on Market

The median days on market in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 10.0%, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very competitive market. This means that homes are selling quickly, and workers relocating to the area may face challenges in finding affordable housing. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other benefits to help attract and retain top talent.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 70, indicating a strong presence of tech, finance, and consulting industries. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, as they can tap into a highly skilled and experienced workforce. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce with limited specialized skills.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy, with a highly skilled workforce and a rapidly expanding housing supply. However, the city's high cost of living and competitive housing market may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these costs and develop strategies to mitigate them. Overall, the city's strengths make it an attractive location for businesses in the tech and finance sectors, but its weaknesses require careful consideration and planning.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B

AVERAGE

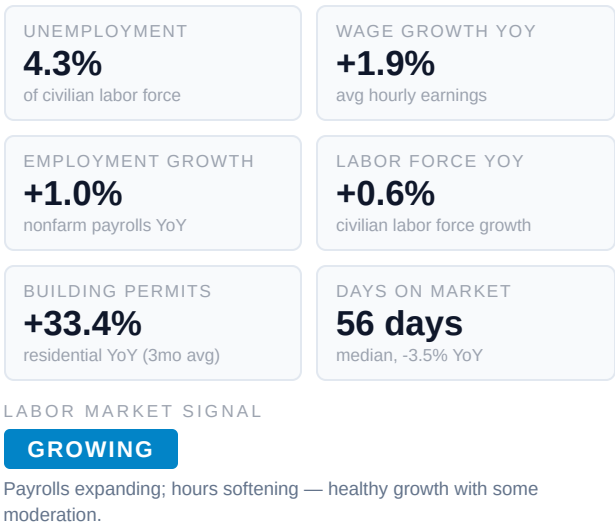
52.9th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth, which stand at 60th and 72nd percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these metrics, alongside its relatively low unemployment rate of 4.30%, which positions it in the 72nd percentile. With employment growth at +0.96% year-over-year, this metro presents a mixed picture of stability and growth.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.42, placing it in the 60th percentile, driven by employment growth of +0.96% and weekly hours deviation of -0.228% from its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit with some moderation in hours worked, indicating that while jobs are being added, the existing workforce is not being overly stretched. This scenario suggests a balanced labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.30%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market with less slack than many of its peers. For a business trying to hire in this market, the practical implication is that it may face challenges in finding suitable candidates, potentially leading to higher wage offers to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is +1.95%, which ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating moderate to slow wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively stable labor cost environment, but workers may not see substantial improvements in their standards of living.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$490/sqft to \$40.39/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.13, and a percentile rank of 6th, the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is relatively expensive. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.6% year-over-year slightly mitigates this, but the city remains in the bottom tier for affordability. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging, as the high cost of living may deter some potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of +0.60% year-over-year, placing it in the 72nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The metro area has seen a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of +33.43%, ranking it in the 84th percentile. This surge in permits signals that housing supply is likely to expand, which could improve affordability and make the area more attractive to relocating workers, thus supporting future workforce growth.

Days on Market

Homes in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area currently sit on the market for a median of 56 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.5%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, corresponding to a bottom-tier percentile rank of 18th, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing quickly.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in the metro area is significant, with a composite score placing it in the 68th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics sectors.

In conclusion, the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a stable and slightly growing labor market, with a tight unemployment situation that may drive up hiring costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which, despite some mitigation from falling PSF, remains a significant deterrent to talent attraction without substantial wage premiums.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

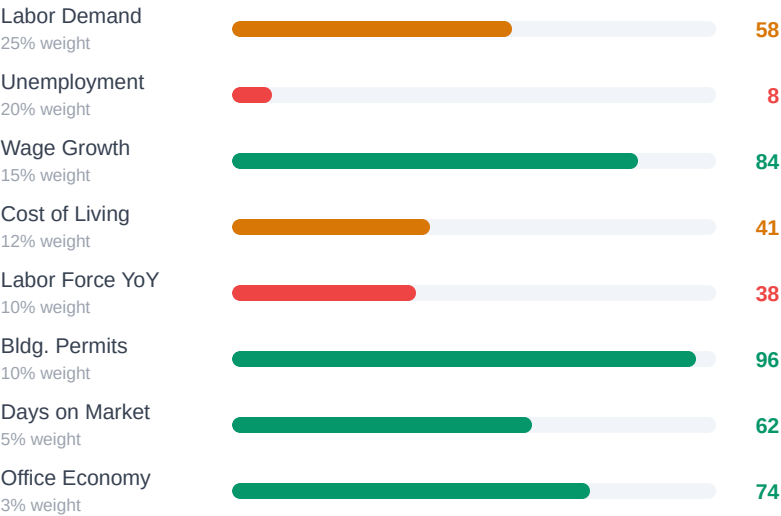
B

AVERAGE

52.3th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 52.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its top-tier wage growth and strong building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its +5.79% year-over-year wage growth and a +93.96% increase in building permits, signaling a dynamic labor market and expanding housing supply. These metrics suggest a city with a strong economy but also potential labor cost pressures.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is +0.81% year-over-year, combined with a -0.048% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.39. This combination signals a moderate expansion in jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some genuine demand but not at an accelerated pace. The labor market is thus characterized by steady, albeit not spectacular, growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue stands at 5.00%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, which means the labor market is relatively tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a company looking to staff up, this market presents a significant recruitment challenge.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.79%, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, which is good for worker purchasing power but may erode profit margins for businesses. Companies should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, with a PSF of \$432/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$47.42, results in a ratio of 9.11, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This indicates that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. The slight decrease in PSF (-1.8% YoY) is a positive sign for affordability. However, the city's cost of living does not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has contracted by -0.77% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand their

workforce may find it challenging due to this declining labor force growth.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant increase of +93.96% in residential building permits year-over-year, signaling a rapid expansion in housing supply. This strong growth in building permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and suggests that the city is actively addressing potential housing shortages, which could improve its attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

Homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue currently sit on the market for a median of 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.3%. This slight increase in days on market, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile, suggests a normalization of the housing market, making it somewhat more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the market remains relatively competitive.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked above average at the 74th percentile, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue offers a dynamic economy with strong wage growth and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses, especially those in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and rapid wage growth, which could pose significant challenges for staffing and labor cost management.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

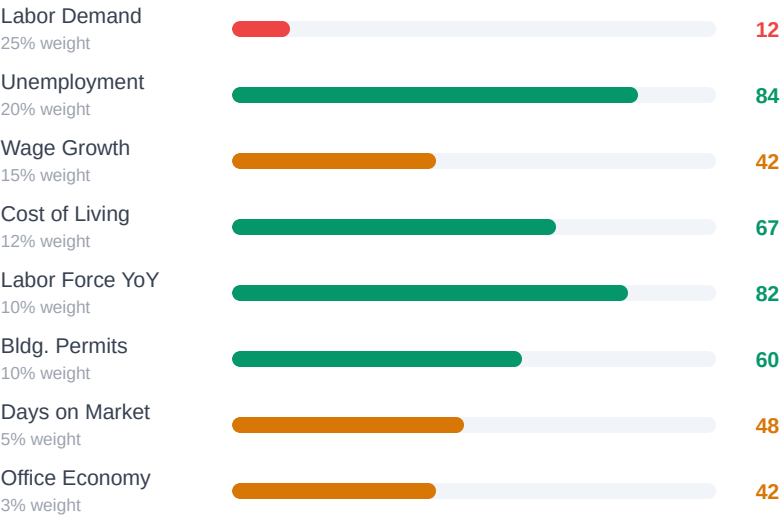
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AVERAGE

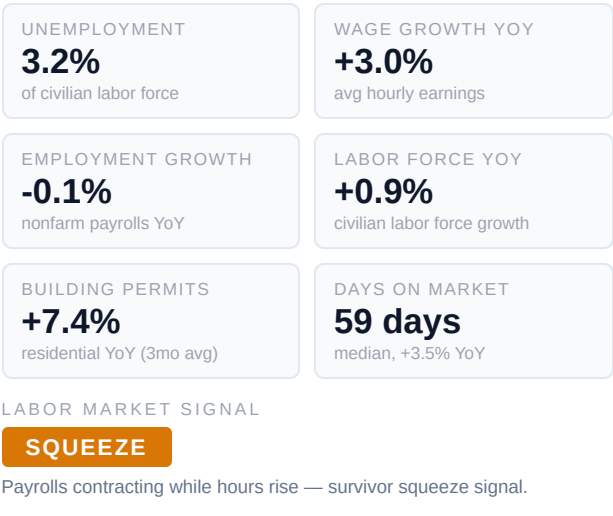
52.0th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a labor force growth rate of 0.88% YoY. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, indicating a tight labor market with an expanding workforce. Specifically, the low unemployment rate and positive labor force growth suggest a competitive yet dynamic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.11% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.454% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.69, which ranks in the bottom tier (12th percentile). This signals a contraction in labor demand, as the slight increase in hours worked is not enough to offset the decline in employment growth. The scenario suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.20%, ranking in the top tier (84th percentile), indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The low unemployment rate implies that workers have more bargaining power, making it essential for employers to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Atlanta is +2.99%, ranking near the median (42nd percentile), indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may not be enough to keep pace with the cost of living, potentially affecting the attractiveness of the city to workers.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks in the 67th percentile, with a PSF of \$195/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.03/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.27. The city is more affordable than many of its peers, particularly since the PSF is falling by 0.5% YoY. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living in Atlanta.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of 0.88% YoY, ranking in the top tier (82nd percentile), indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the increasing labor force can provide a steady stream of potential employees for businesses.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Atlanta is increasing by 7.37% YoY, ranking above average (60th percentile), signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Atlanta is 59 days, with a YoY increase of 3.5%, ranking near the median (48th percentile). This indicates a relatively competitive market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are selling at a moderate pace. The rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Atlanta has an office economy score that ranks in the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech, finance, or consulting talent.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies that can navigate the competitive hiring environment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for upward pressure on wages due to the low unemployment rate, which may impact labor costs and profitability.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

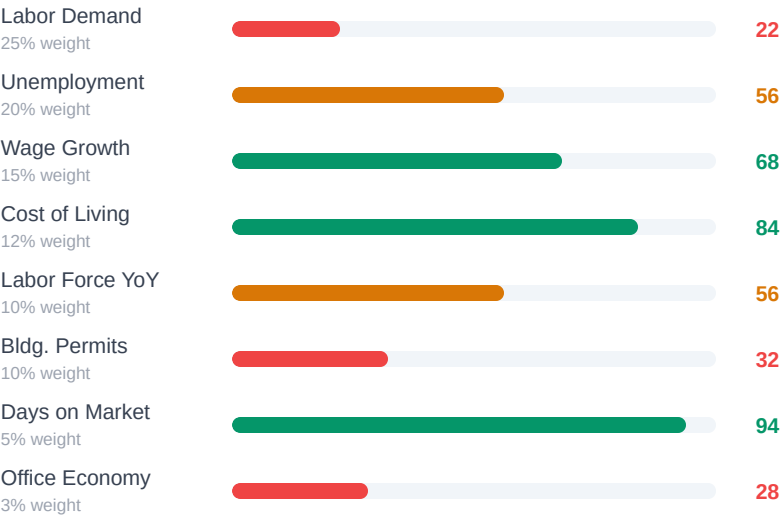
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AVERAGE

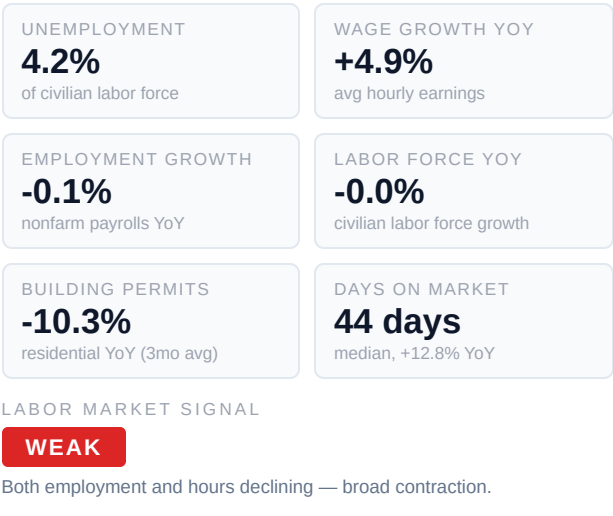
51.3th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living, scoring 84th percentile. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with wage growth at +4.94% YoY and a cost of living ratio of \$214/sqft to \$37.54/hr, indicating a relatively affordable environment. This affordability is further underscored by the PSF falling -3.2% YoY.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.10% YoY, combined with weekly hours deviating -0.673% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the labor market is not experiencing significant growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.16 further supports this, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.20%, placing it near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it does not indicate a highly competitive market for workers, which could influence wage negotiations and hiring strategies.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area is +4.94% YoY, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This level of wage growth signifies a moderate to fast increase in labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in rising labor costs, but the positive impact on local consumer demand could offset some of these expenses.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score that ranks at the 84th percentile, indicating it is more affordable compared to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of \$214/sqft to \$37.54/hr, coupled with a -3.2% YoY decrease in PSF, makes the city attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. This affordability is a talent attraction advantage, potentially easing hiring and relocation processes for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has grown -0.04% YoY, indicating a nearly stagnant labor force supply. This slight contraction suggests that the workforce supply is not expanding significantly, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion plans.

Building Permits

The city has experienced a -10.35% YoY change in residential building permits, signaling a tightening in future housing supply. This decrease in permits suggests that affordability and workforce accommodation might become more challenging in the future, potentially affecting the city's attractiveness for both businesses and workers.

Days on Market

Homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson currently sit on the market for 44 days, with a +12.8% YoY increase, ranking at the 94th percentile. This slower market indicates that homes are taking longer to sell, making the city more accessible for relocating workers who have more time to find suitable housing. However, this trend also suggests a less competitive housing market, which could have implications for local demand and economic activity.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson ranks at the 28th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these areas compared to other cities. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a large professional or office-based workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Baltimore-Columbia-Towson offers businesses an environment with above-average wage growth and a highly affordable cost of living, making it attractive for talent acquisition without significant wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's below-average labor demand and tightening housing supply, which could impact future hiring capacity and workforce accommodation.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

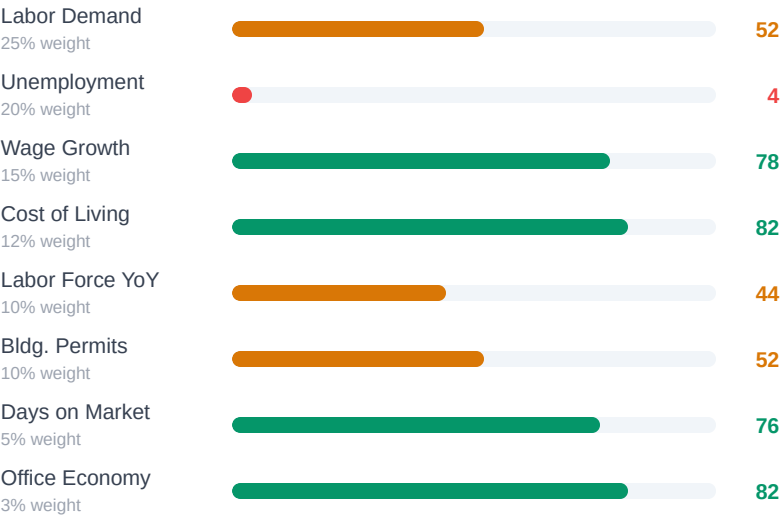
B

AVERAGE

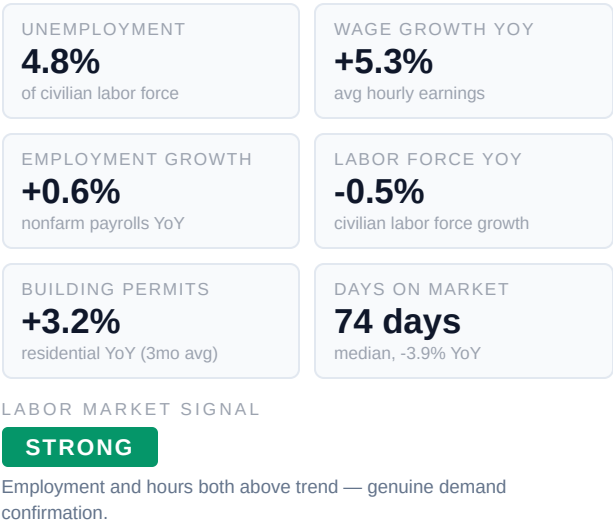
51.2th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of +5.33% YoY and a cost of living ratio of \$233/sqft vs \$37.12/hr, resulting in a top-tier affordability score of 82th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +0.56% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.240% from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in job creation, with hours worked also rising above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.32, ranking near the median at 52th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate translates to higher wage pressure. In practical terms, companies looking to staff up in this city may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +5.33%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when operating in this city, but can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of \$233/sqft vs \$37.12/hr, with a top-tier affordability score of 82th percentile. This means that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -5.7% YoY further enhances the city's affordability advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is contracting at a rate of -0.50% YoY, ranking near the median at 44th percentile. This decline in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the shrinking pool of available workers could limit businesses' ability to find qualified talent.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a +3.19% YoY increase in residential building permits, ranking near the median at 52th percentile. This moderate expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is taking steps to accommodate its growing workforce, which should help maintain affordability and attract more talent in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 74 days, with a YoY decrease of -3.9%, ranking above average at 76th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find suitable housing. However, the decreasing trend in days on market may indicate a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 3.38, ranking in the top tier at 82th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable living costs, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may lead to higher wage pressure and challenges in finding qualified talent, making it essential to factor in competitive salaries and benefits packages when operating in this city.

Columbus

Columbus

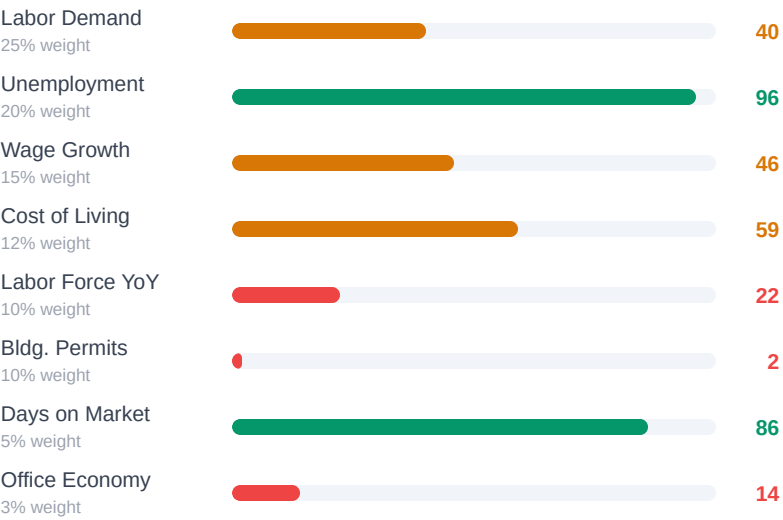
B

AVERAGE

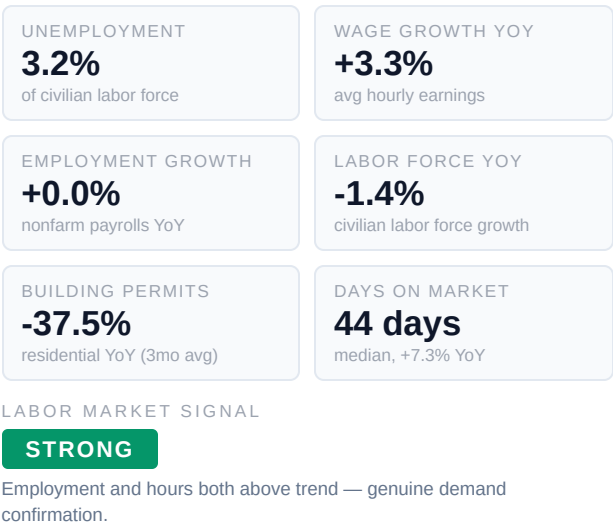
50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it 50.3th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.57. The city's economic character is also defined by its stagnant labor force growth and sharp decline in building permits. Specifically, the labor demand and unemployment metrics, with scores of 40th and 96th percentile respectively, set the tone for the city's current economic situation.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.02% year-over-year, combined with a +0.246% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one. This combination indicates that while jobs are being added, the increase in hours worked suggests that the existing workforce is shouldering a slightly heavier load. The near-median percentile rank of 40th suggests that labor demand is neither exceptionally strong nor weak.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus stands at 3.20%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, which signifies a very tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Columbus is +3.31% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$205/sqft to \$34.40/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 0.5% in PSF, Columbus ranks in the near-median 59th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.35% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to this shrinking labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.46%, placing Columbus in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The lack of new housing developments may constrain the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus are currently sitting on the market for 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.3%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This slower market means that relocating workers may find it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is less competitive. However, this could also indicate a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, Columbus may be more accommodating to industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a relatively affordable location with a tight labor market, which can be both a blessing and a curse. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's shrinking labor force and sharp decline in building permits, which may limit the availability of talent and housing for a growing workforce.

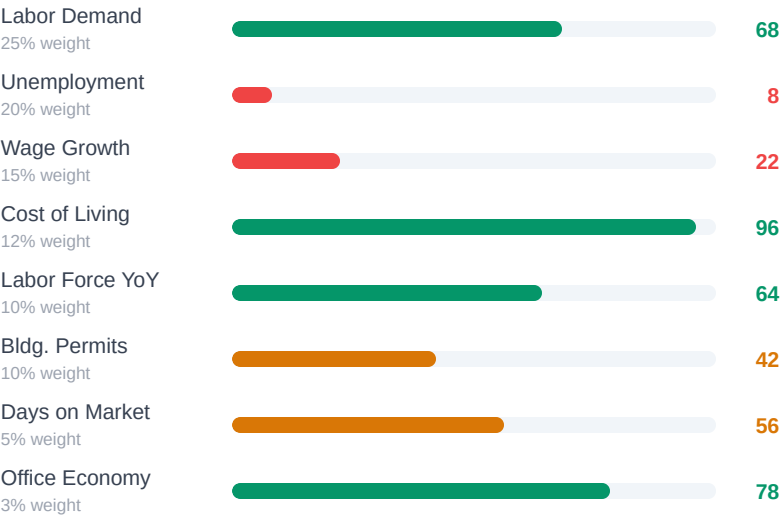
Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

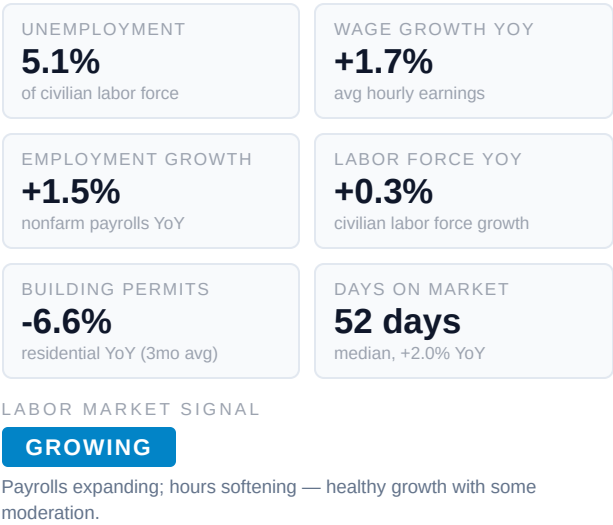
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.2th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand composite score, ranking at the 68th percentile, and its extremely affordable cost of living, with a ratio of \$169/sqft to \$36.90/hr, ranking at the 96th percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics suggest a city with genuine job growth and an attractive environment for talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.46% year-over-year, combined with a -0.639% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and hours are running slightly below trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 further supports this interpretation, ranking at the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.10%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.71%, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means workers have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a cost of living ratio of \$169/sqft to \$36.90/hr, with the price per square foot falling by -2.3% year-over-year, ranking at the 96th percentile. This makes the city extremely affordable relative to its peers, which is a significant talent attraction advantage. Businesses can attract workers without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of +0.28% year-over-year, ranking at the 64th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, which is a positive sign for hiring capacity. However, the growth rate is relatively modest, suggesting that businesses may still face some challenges in finding workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is decreasing by -6.61% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.0%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible, for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 3.34, ranking at the 78th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of genuine labor demand and extremely affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high unemployment rate, which could impact local consumer demand and, in turn, businesses reliant on it.

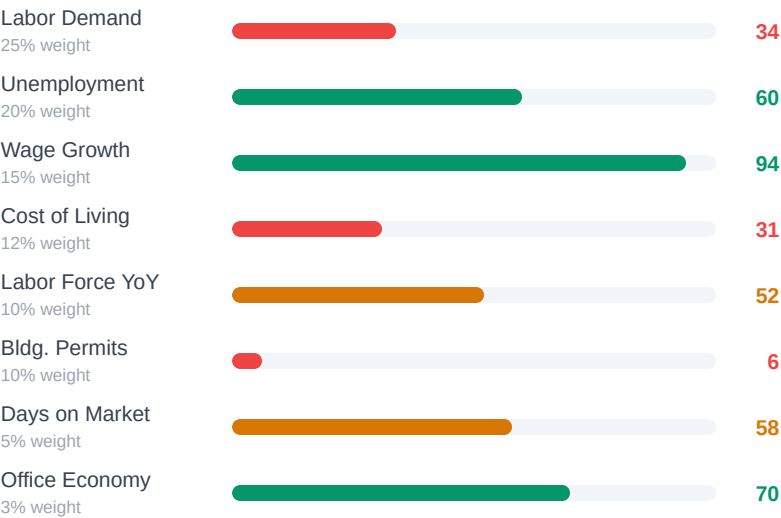
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

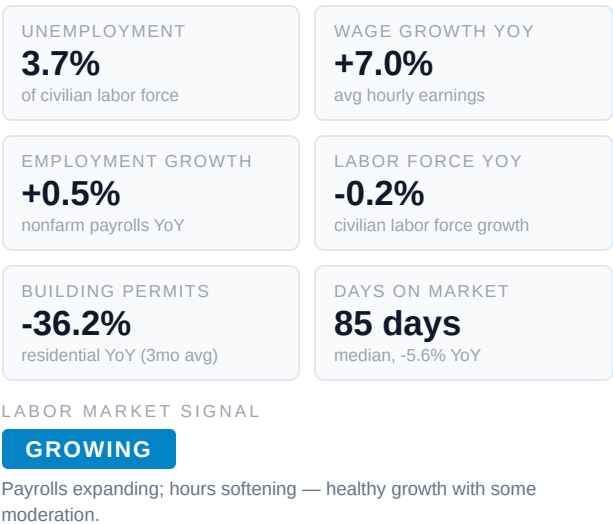
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.1th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.02%, and its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.52. These metrics signal a complex economic environment, with rising labor costs and a relatively slow pace of job creation.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.48% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.452% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as the slow job growth is accompanied by hours worked that are below trend. This suggests that the labor market is not experiencing significant pressure, despite the strong wage growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.70%, ranking it at the 60th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, with some slack but not a significant amount. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that there may be some competition for talent, and wage pressure could be a concern.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.02%, ranking it at the 94th percentile. This is a fast rate of wage growth, indicating rising labor costs for employers. However, it also means that workers in the city have strong purchasing power, which could be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 31st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$355/sqft to \$34.68/hr, or 10.24. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which could make it difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that the price per square foot is falling -0.8% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates that the labor force is contracting slightly, which could create a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider this when planning their workforce expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is falling -36.23% year-over-year, ranking it at the 6th percentile. This signals a significant tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it harder for workers to relocate to the city. This is a concern for businesses that rely on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the decline in days on market is slowing. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is competitive, and they may need to act quickly to secure a home.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a professional and office worker share that ranks it at the 70th percentile, with a score of 3.10. This indicates a deep talent pool in these sectors, making the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and headquarters operations. However, it may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominated sectors.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of companies. However, the city's relatively expensive cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant concerns that could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent, and this is the single biggest risk or constraint that decision-makers should factor in when considering a location in this city.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

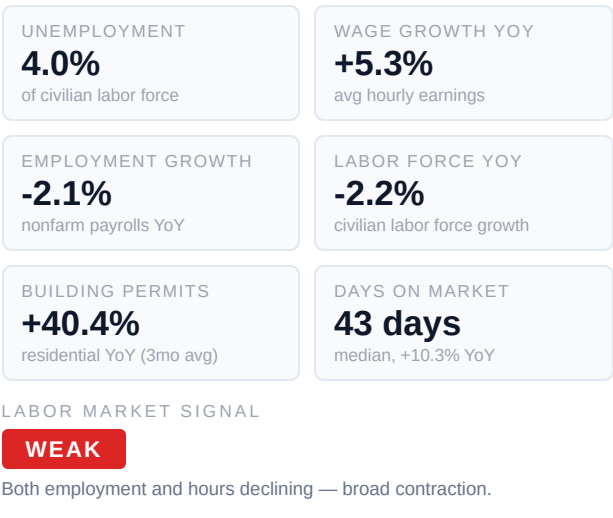
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.5th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.31%. The combination of a -2.15% employment growth rate and a -0.969% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.15% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.969% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also a potentially shrinking talent pool.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.00%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is relatively strong.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.31%, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. However, this may also put pressure on businesses to increase wages to retain talent.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score ranking at the 76th percentile, with a PSF of \$298/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.17/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.60. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking at the 6th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is contracting, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing at a rate of 40.37% year-over-year, ranking at the 90th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%, ranking at the 90th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a home and negotiate a better price.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This means that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable living costs, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's weak labor demand and shrinking labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses, particularly those that rely on a growing and skilled workforce.

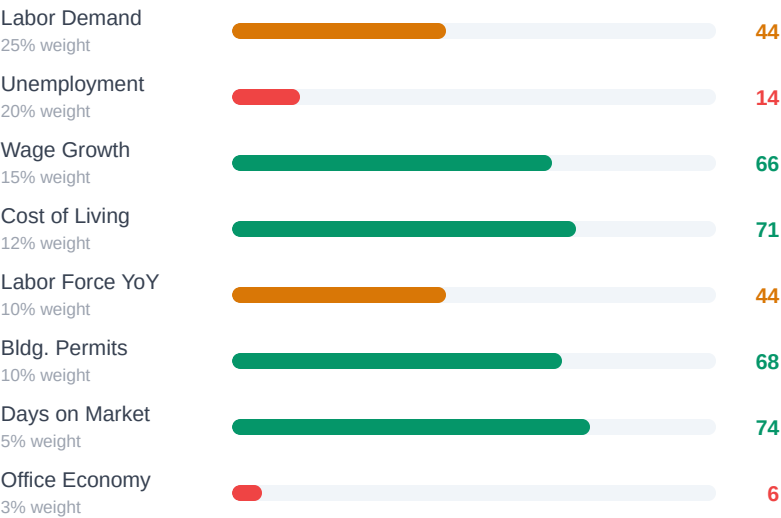
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

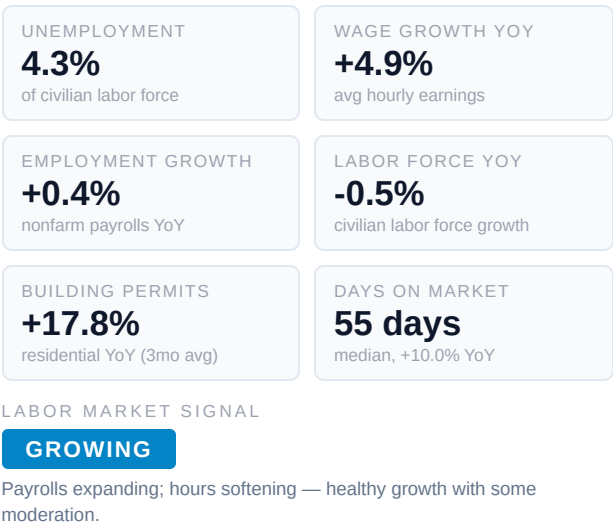
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.4th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 4.86% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 4.30%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics suggest that Oklahoma City has a strong but competitive labor environment.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is 0.43% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.070% from its own 12-month baseline. The combination of these metrics signals a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.83, indicating a moderate expansion of jobs but with hours worked slightly below trend. This suggests that while the city is adding jobs, the existing workforce is not yet experiencing significant pressure to work longer hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.30%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City's year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.86%, ranking it above average at the 66th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$171/sqft to \$33.54/hr, Oklahoma City ranks above average at the 71st percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums. The stable year-over-year change in PSF (+0.0% YoY) suggests that affordability is not significantly changing.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the available workforce is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

Oklahoma City has seen a 17.78% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking it above average at the 68th percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the current pace of construction may not keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 55 days, with a 10.0% year-over-year increase. This above-average percentile rank of 74th indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is 0.60, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, the city may be more attractive to industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a strong labor environment with high wage growth, but its tight labor market and limited labor force growth pose significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for rising labor costs and the need to attract workers from other areas to support business growth.

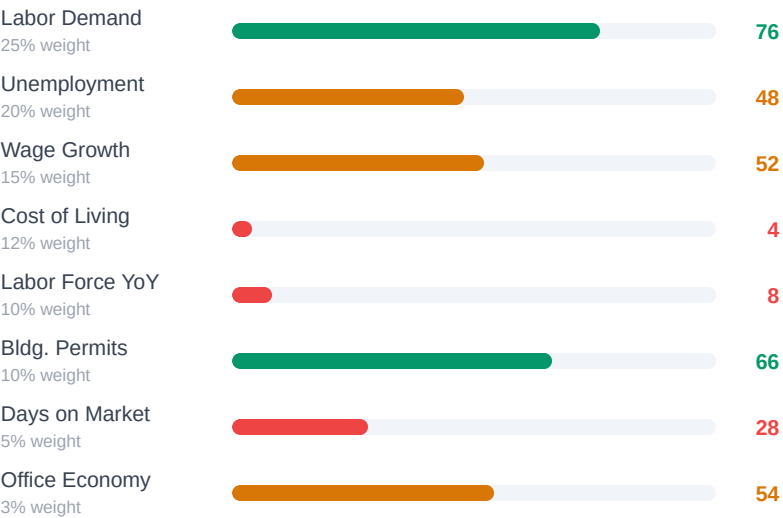
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

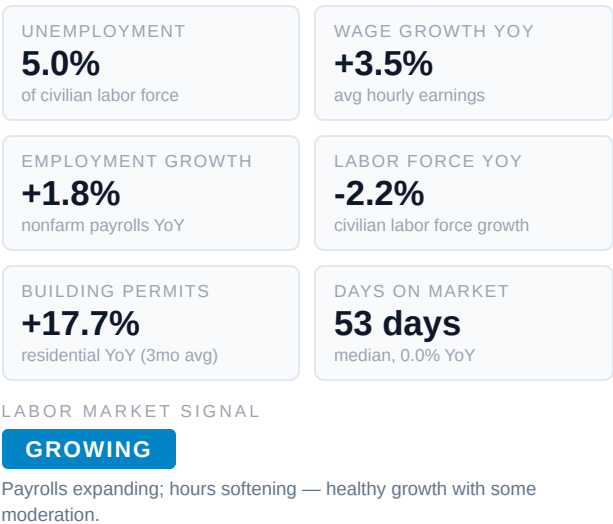
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.3th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 6.18 ranking it at the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile due to a high PSF to wages ratio of \$652/sqft to \$41.61/hr. The labor demand and cost of living metrics signal a complex economic environment, with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 1.83% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.681%. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, indicating a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.18 supports this interpretation, ranking the city at the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 5.00%, ranking it at the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of workers, and businesses may still face some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.48%, ranking it at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in moderate wage increases when planning for labor costs.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living percentile rank of 4, indicating that it is one of the more expensive cities in the US, with a PSF to wages ratio of \$652/sqft to \$41.61/hr. However, the PSF is falling by 2.1% year-over-year, which may help improve affordability in the future. The high cost of living makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the city's expensive housing market may deter some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is shrinking by 2.18% year-over-year, ranking it at the 8th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses

may need to consider this trend when planning for future hiring needs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is increasing by 17.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 66th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is taking steps to address its affordability challenges, which may improve the prospects for workforce accommodation in the future. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 53 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, ranking it at the 28th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the fast-paced market may make it challenging to find and secure housing, potentially affecting their decision to move.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 2.66, ranking it at the 54th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting industries. However, the city may be less suited for businesses that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics sectors.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges. While the city has a strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, its high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply pose significant risks for businesses looking to attract and retain talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive housing market, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to compete for talent.

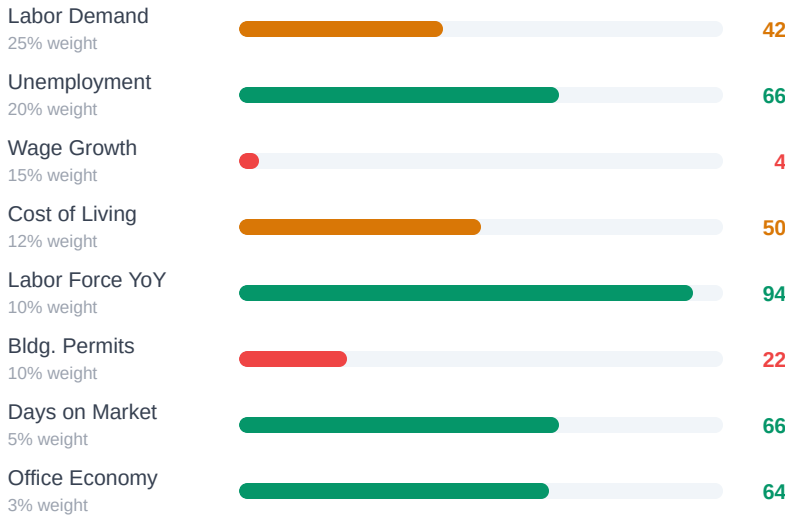
Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.1th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+0.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.8%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-16.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
55 days
median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of only 0.10%, and its strong labor force growth, with a 1.80% year-over-year expansion. These two metrics signal a mixed economic environment, with a growing workforce but limited upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.438% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for workers but not enough to drive significant increases in hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 4.66 ranks near the median, at the 42nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, with some slack but generally favorable conditions for workers. For a business trying to hire in Cleveland, this means that recruiting and retaining top talent may be challenging, with potential upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 0.10%, Cleveland's wage environment is stagnant. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and may not see significant increases in their purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living is near the median, with a percentile rank of 50th. The city's PSF of \$143/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.00/hr result in a ratio of 4.21. Although the PSF is increasing by 13.5% year-over-year, the city's affordability is still relatively neutral. This means that Cleveland may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living is not particularly low or high compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. However, the city's stagnant wage growth may limit the attractiveness of these new workers.

Building Permits

Cleveland's residential building permits are decreasing by 16.61% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may face increasing competition for talent and rising labor costs due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%. This ranks above average at the 66th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to Cleveland, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with more time to find and secure a home. However, this slower market may also signal weaker demand and limited upward pressure on prices.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is 2.92, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries with limited specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a mixed economic environment with a growing labor force but stagnant wage growth. The city's relatively tight labor market and limited housing supply may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and attract top talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for increasing labor costs and competition for talent due to the tightening housing market and limited upward pressure on wages.

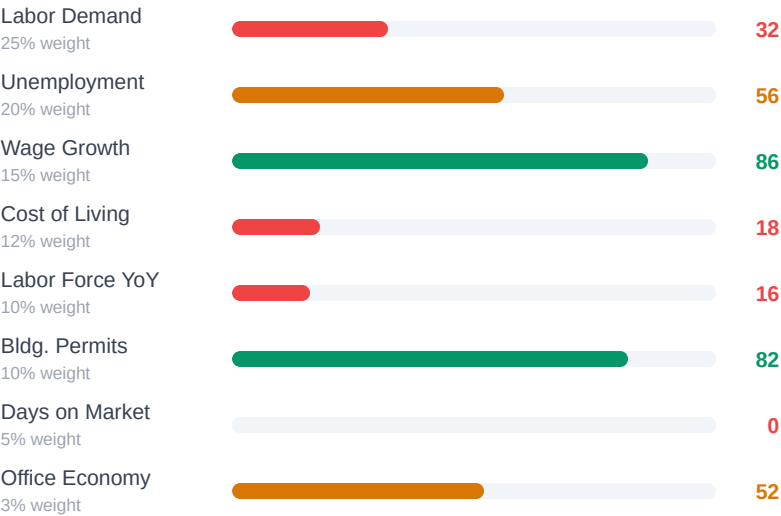
San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

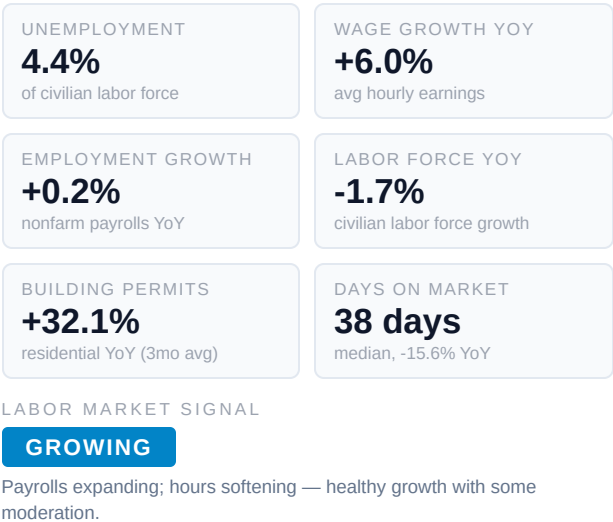
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.7th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.99%, and its extremely competitive housing market, with homes selling at a median of 38 days on market and a year-over-year decrease of 15.6% in days on market. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.22% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.149% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.46, which ranks 32nd percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the small employment growth is accompanied by a decrease in weekly hours worked. This suggests that businesses may not face intense competition for workers, but the overall labor market is not expanding rapidly.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 4.40%, which ranks 56th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This means that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a highly competitive market, and businesses may still face some challenges in attracting top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 5.99%, which ranks 86th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising rapidly, and workers have strong bargaining power. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent, but workers will also have more purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses.

Cost of Living

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a cost of living score that ranks 18th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$619/sqft to \$49.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 12.42. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that the price per square foot is decreasing by 3.9% year-over-year may provide some relief, but the overall cost of living remains high.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.71% year-over-year, which ranks 16th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract talent, as the local labor pool is not expanding.

Building Permits

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has seen a year-over-year increase of 32.14% in building permits, which ranks 82nd percentile. This indicates that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and workforce accommodation in the future. However, the current competitive housing market may still pose challenges for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 38 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 15.6%. This ranks 0th percentile, indicating an extremely competitive market. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is highly competitive, making it challenging to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a professional and office worker share of 2.58, which ranks 52nd percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for industries that require a large workforce or have limited specialized roles.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a highly competitive housing market. However, the biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging labor market, with a shrinking labor force and extremely competitive housing market, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

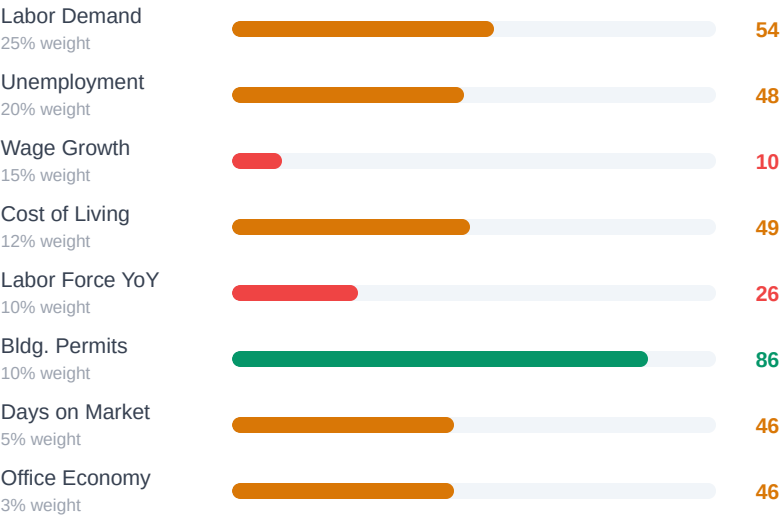
Birmingham

Birmingham

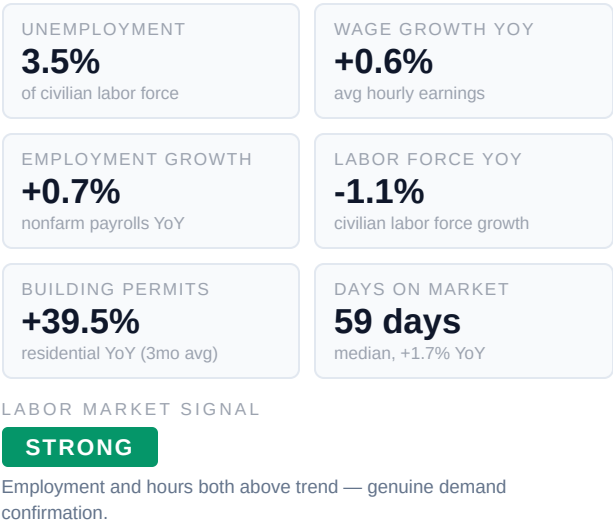
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.4th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.35 and its bottom-tier wage growth of +0.57% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with moderate job growth but stagnant wage increases.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.65% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.140% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.35, ranking near the median at 54th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 3.50%, ranking near the median at 48th percentile. This indicates a moderately tight labor market, with some slack but not excessive. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may require some effort, but it is not an insurmountable challenge.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Birmingham is +0.57% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. This could impact the attractiveness of the city to workers who prioritize wage growth.

Cost of Living

Birmingham has a cost of living score ranking near the median at 49th percentile, with a PSF of \$159/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.79/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.85. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.6% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This suggests that Birmingham is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.10% year-over-year, ranking below average at 26th percentile. This implies that the workforce supply is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring capacity in the city. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from outside the city or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

Building permits in Birmingham are increasing by +39.50% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile. This significant rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for businesses considering locating in the city, as it indicates a proactive approach to addressing potential housing shortages.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Birmingham is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This ranks near the median at 46th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, the relatively moderate days on market suggests a competitive but not extremely challenging housing market. However, the rising trend in days on market could indicate a normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at 46th percentile, with a composite score of 2.30. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool in professional sectors, making the city suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office skills. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a mixed economic environment with moderate job growth, stagnant wage increases, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in the city is the shrinking labor force supply, which could pose challenges for hiring capacity and talent attraction. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when evaluating Birmingham as a potential business location.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

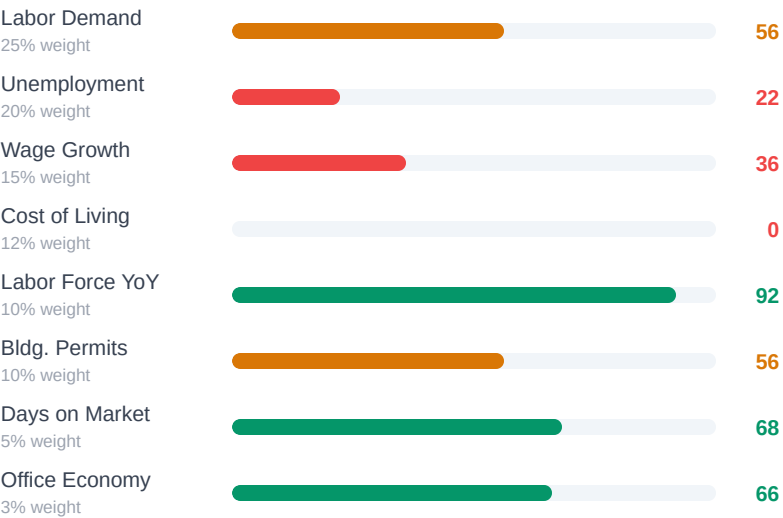
C+

POOR

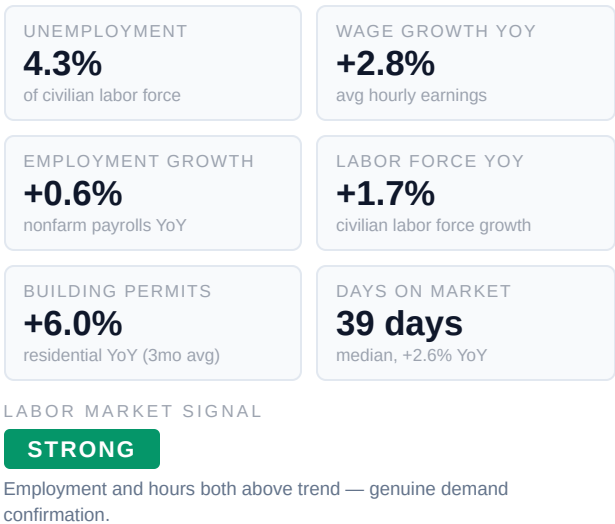
44.0th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44th out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.96, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. The labor demand composite score of 5.37, near the median at the 56th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, combined with a +0.226% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This indicates that jobs are being added, and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The near-median percentile rank of 56th for labor demand composite score reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it at the 22nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could impact hiring strategies.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +2.76%, ranking it at the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is not excessively high. Workers in this city are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power, but it is not exceptionally strong.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score ranking it at the 0th percentile, making it one of the most expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF of \$362/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.34. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage for talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living. The 9.4% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 92nd percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a growing pool of potential workers. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find this growth beneficial for their staffing needs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +5.95% year-over-year, ranking it at the 56th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This growth suggests that the city is experiencing some relief in terms of future affordability and workforce accommodation, but it is not exceptionally strong.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.6%, ranking it at the 68th percentile. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling excessively quickly. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score ranking it at the 66th percentile, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and a rapidly expanding workforce supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's extremely high cost of living, which could significantly impact talent attraction and retention strategies, requiring wage premiums to remain competitive.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

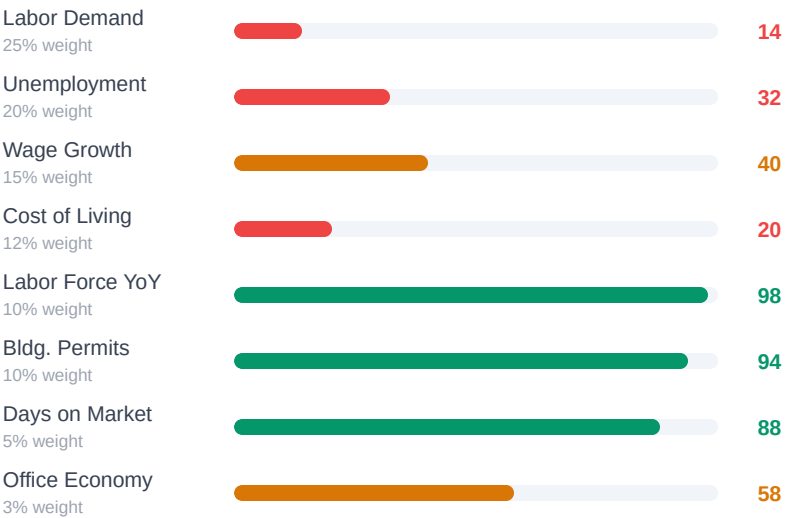
C+

POOR

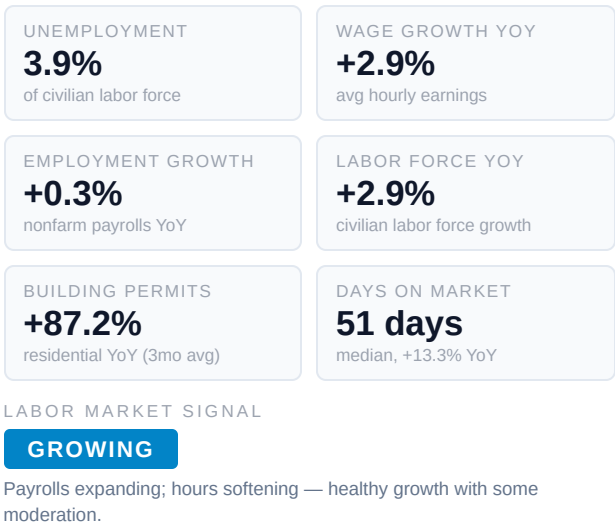
43.7th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high labor force growth, with a 98th percentile rank. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 3.73 and labor force growth rate of +2.87% YoY are the key metrics shaping this city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.27% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.951% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of slow job growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.73 is in the bottom tier, ranking 14th percentile, which suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.90%, ranking 32nd percentile, indicating a below-average level of slack in the labor market. This means the market is relatively tight, making it harder for businesses to hire, with potential upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +2.89%, ranking near the median at 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the pace of wage growth is not exceptionally high, which may limit the city's attractiveness to businesses seeking to control labor costs.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$458/sqft to \$45.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.09, and a percentile rank of 20th, the city is relatively expensive. The fact that PSF is falling -1.5% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score is still below average. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent without corresponding salary adjustments.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This top-tier growth rate, ranking 98th percentile, suggests a favorable environment for hiring, with a growing pool of potential employees. As a result, businesses looking to

expand their workforce may find this city an attractive location.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +87.24%, ranking 94th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This surge in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the current pace of growth may lead to short-term fluctuations in the housing market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.3%, ranking 88th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower, more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests that the housing market is not as competitive as in other cities.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.84, ranking 58th percentile, the city has a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that Boston-Cambridge-Newton is suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industries requiring a more specialized or industrial workforce.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but the low labor demand and relatively high cost of living are significant constraints. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the potential for wage pressure and hiring challenges due to the tight labor market, which may offset the benefits of the city's growing workforce and improving affordability.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

C+

POOR

43.5th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		62
25% weight		
Unemployment		48
20% weight		
Wage Growth		26
15% weight		
Cost of Living		65
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		18
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		20
10% weight		
Days on Market		22
5% weight		
Office Economy		60
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -17.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 57 days median, -1.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking 43.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.42, and its relatively low wage growth, at +1.94% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics suggest a city with expanding job opportunities but moderate pressure on labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.31% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.687% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, with both more jobs being added and hours worked above the trend. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.10%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.94%, which is below average, ranking at the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for businesses looking to control costs, it also means that workers may have less bargaining power and lower purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking at the 65th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$280/sqft to \$42.59/hr, or 6.57. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF value (-3.5% year-over-year) contributing to its high affordability score. This makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without having to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -1.67% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. This could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by -17.89% year-over-year, ranking at the 20th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of skilled workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent to the area.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 60th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and relatively affordable living costs, making it an attractive location for talent recruitment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's affordability and labor demand.

Fresno

Fresno

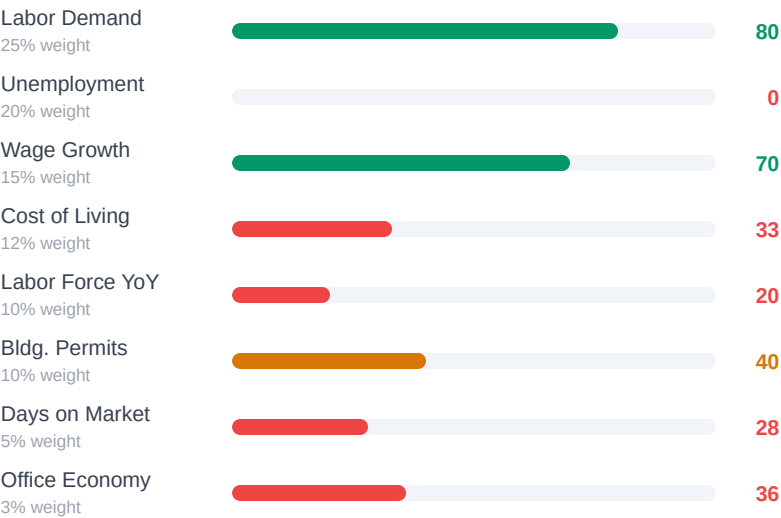
C+

POOR

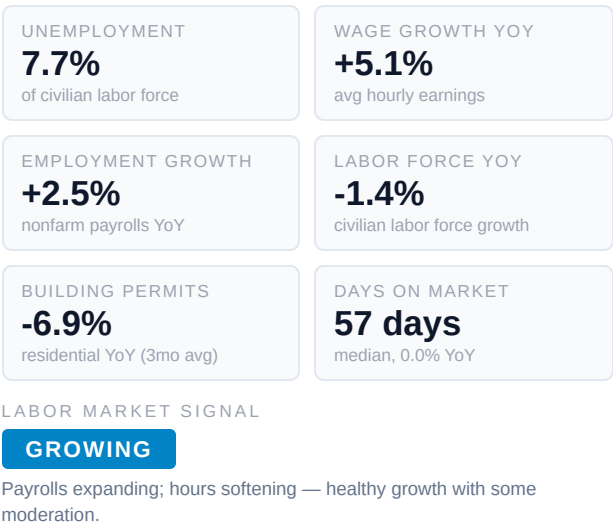
42.9th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier, and its high unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at 7.70%. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both strong job growth and significant slack.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 2.47% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are 1.481% below trend. The combination of these two metrics signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs at a rate above the national average, but hours worked are slightly below trend, indicating that the growth is not solely due to existing workers taking on more hours. This suggests a healthy labor market with room for expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is in the bottom tier. This indicates a labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher number of unemployed individuals.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is 5.14% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 70th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks in the 33rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$263/sqft to \$33.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.77. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 0.4% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.42% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno has decreased by 6.89% year-over-year. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Fresno is 57 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively slow pace indicates a buyer-friendly market, which can make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also suggests that the housing market may not be as competitive as in other cities.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share ranks in the 36th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but more suitable for industries with different labor requirements.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a complex labor market with strong job growth but significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire but also posing challenges due to its relatively high cost of living and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering Fresno as a business location is the city's shrinking labor force, which can limit hiring capacity and require wage premiums to attract talent.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

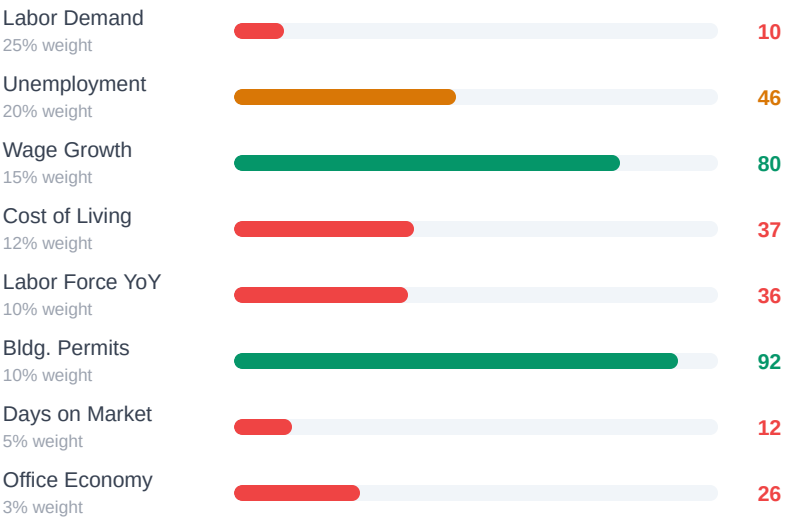
C+

POOR

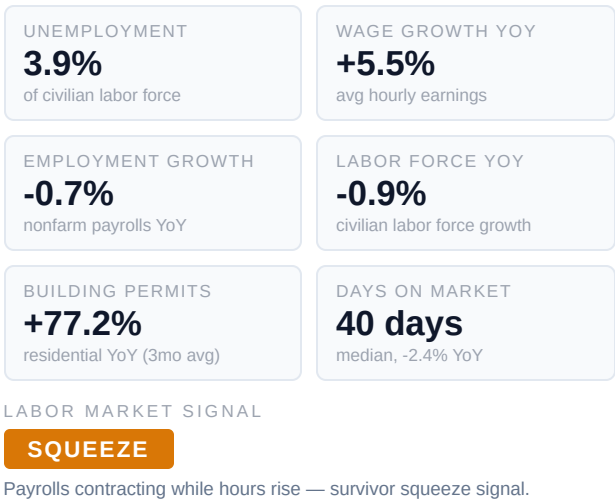
42.3th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 42.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, and strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.54% in hourly earnings, ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.68% year-over-year, and weekly hours are running 0.075% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the small increase in hours worked is not enough to offset the decline in employment growth, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.90%, which places it near the median at the 46th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets, but still presents some challenges in finding the right talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 5.54%, which is a strong increase ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This implies rising labor costs for employers but also good news for worker purchasing power, as higher wages can support local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38, and a percentile rank of 37th, this city is below average in terms of affordability. This means that while it may not require significant wage premiums to attract talent, it does not have a strong talent attraction advantage due to its cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -0.91% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This presents a structural headwind for hiring, as a shrinking workforce limits the supply of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +77.17%, which is a significant increase ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and support workforce accommodation in the

future.

Days on Market

Homes in this metro area are currently sitting on the market for 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.4%. This suggests a relatively fast-paced market, which can make it competitive and challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in this metro area is below average, with a percentile rank of 26th. This indicates a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized professional or office skills, making it less suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that rely heavily on such talent.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex mix of strong wage growth and weak labor demand, suggesting both opportunities for businesses that can navigate its challenges and risks, particularly in terms of hiring and talent attraction. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in this area.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

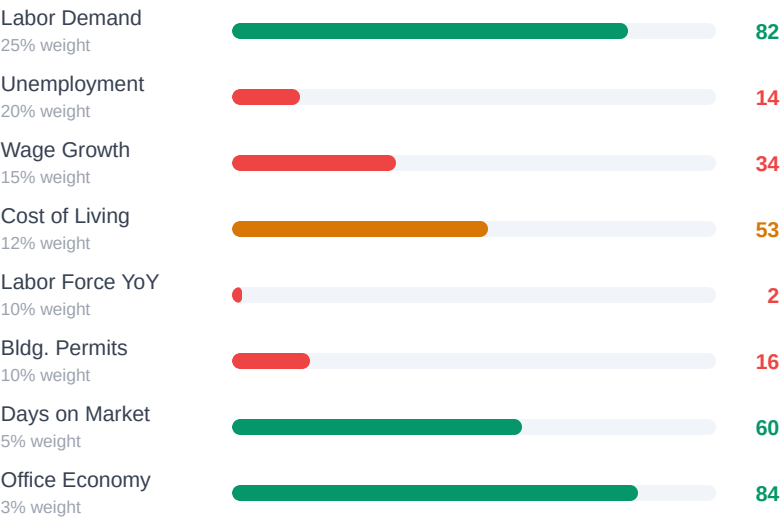
C+

POOR

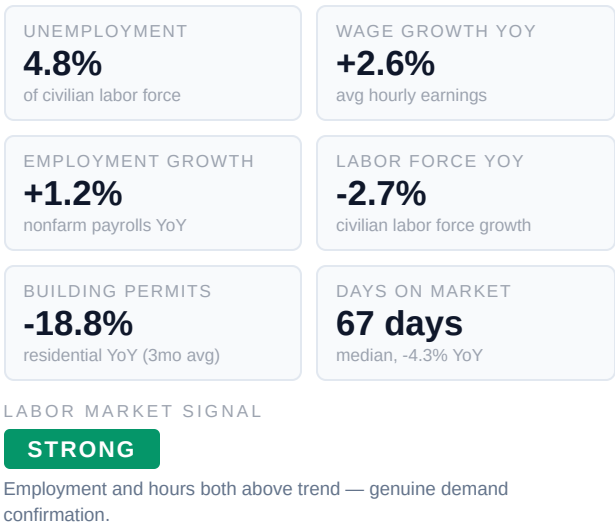
42.1th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 82nd percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the 14th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 6.34, driven by a +1.23% employment growth rate and +0.313% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.23% and weekly hours deviation of +0.313% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% is relatively low, ranking in the 14th percentile, which means the market is tight. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.61% is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. However, the relatively slow wage growth may also mean that workers have limited purchasing power, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is near the median, with a percentile rank of 53rd, and a PSF to earnings ratio of 7.03 (\$264/sqft vs \$37.56/hr). The fact that PSF is falling by -1.5% YoY is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The shrinking labor pool is a structural headwind for hiring and may require businesses to adapt their recruitment strategies.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -18.76%, which is in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of new talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 60th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing days on market could also indicate a healthy and competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.52, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the tightening housing supply and declining labor force growth, which could limit hiring capacity and talent attraction. The city's low unemployment rate and moderate wage growth also imply that businesses may need to adapt their recruitment and compensation strategies to succeed in this market. Overall, the city's economic character is complex, and businesses should carefully weigh these factors when making location decisions.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

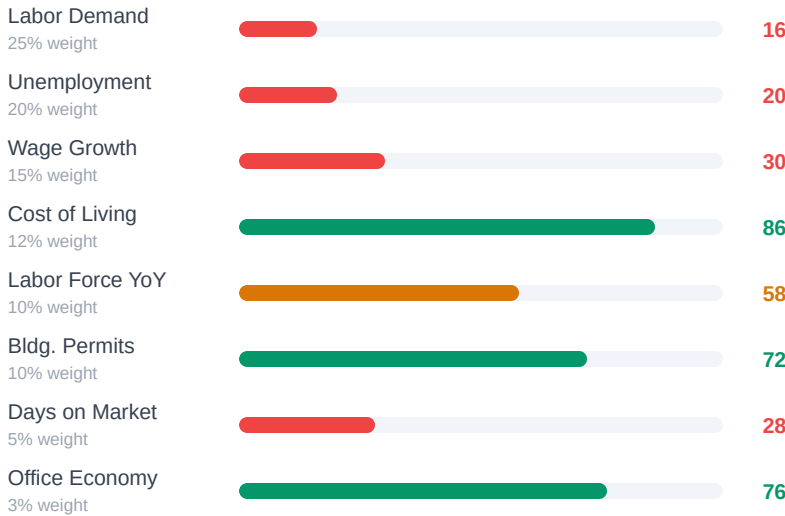
C+

POOR

39.5th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

68 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the top tier at 86th percentile. The labor demand is characterized by a low employment growth rate of 0.85% and a negative deviation in weekly hours of -1.731%, indicating a weak labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 0.85%, which is relatively low, and the weekly hours deviation is -1.731%, indicating that hours are running below trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 3.99 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the bottom tier at 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.70%, which is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that they may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 2.20%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting talent.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living ranked in the top tier at 86th percentile, with a PSF of \$170/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.24. The PSF is also falling by 4.0% year-over-year, making the city even more affordable. This high affordability ranking means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work here without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of 0.10% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at 58th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a modest pace. The implication for hiring

capacity is that businesses may face some challenges in finding new talent, but the growing labor force provides some opportunities for recruitment.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by 19.22% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at 72nd percentile. This rising trend in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to attract and retain talent in the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking at the 28th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the stable days on market indicates a balanced market, rather than a rapidly changing one.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy ranking at the 76th percentile. This indicates that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, the city may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which require a different type of workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and access to a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to manage costs while still attracting talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth or expansion.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

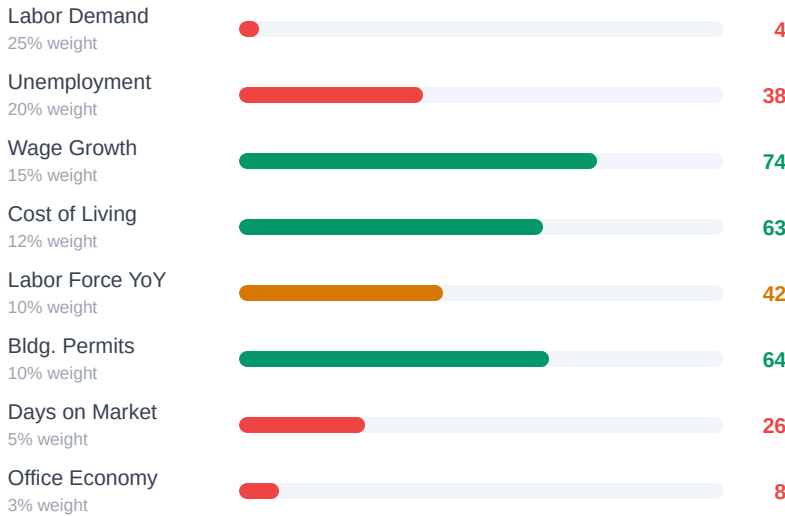
C+

POOR

39.4th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.6%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+12.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

61 days

median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its above-average wage growth, at 5.27% year-over-year. The combination of a -1.44% employment growth rate and a -0.393% weekly hours deviation signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.393% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for labor, but also indicates a slower economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking it in the 38th percentile, which indicates a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This means that while there is some slack in the market, businesses may still face challenges in finding the right talent, and wage pressure may be moderate. However, the market is not as competitive as in cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.27%, which is above average and ranks in the 74th percentile. This indicates that wages are rising faster than in most other cities, which may lead to higher labor costs for employers but also increases worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher wage expenses, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks in the 63rd percentile, with a PSF of \$304/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.21. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -2.2% year-over-year also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, which indicates a slight contraction in the labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may lead to

increased competition for talent. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by 12.62% year-over-year, which signals that housing supply is expanding. This is a positive indicator for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in new housing stock to support growing demand. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the market is not extremely slow, and workers may still face some competition when searching for housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro ranks in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and above-average wage growth, which can be attractive for workers. However, the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor pool pose significant risks for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area, and decision-makers should carefully consider these constraints when evaluating this location. Overall, the city's economic character is complex, and businesses must weigh the pros and cons before making a location decision.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

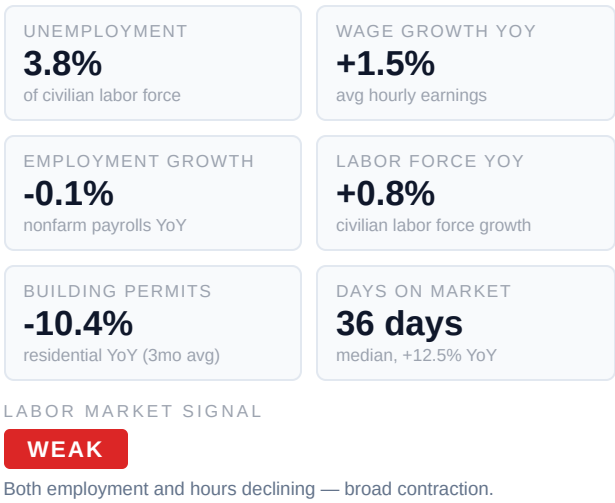
39.4th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.17 ranking it in the 24th percentile, and its slow wage growth, at +1.46% year-over-year, ranking it in the 16th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.09% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.171% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, ranking it in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.46%, ranking it in the 16th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score ranking it in the 14th percentile, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.30. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising +2.2% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +0.85% year-over-year, ranking it in the 80th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, the slow wage growth and high cost of living may offset this advantage.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha has decreased by -10.38% year-over-year, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.5%, ranking it in the 92nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also signal a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

Milwaukee-Waukesha has an office economy score ranking it in the 30th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 1.94 out of 5. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a relatively tight labor market and an expanding labor force, but it is also characterized by slow wage growth, a high cost of living, and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and slow wage growth, which may require offering wage premiums to remain competitive.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

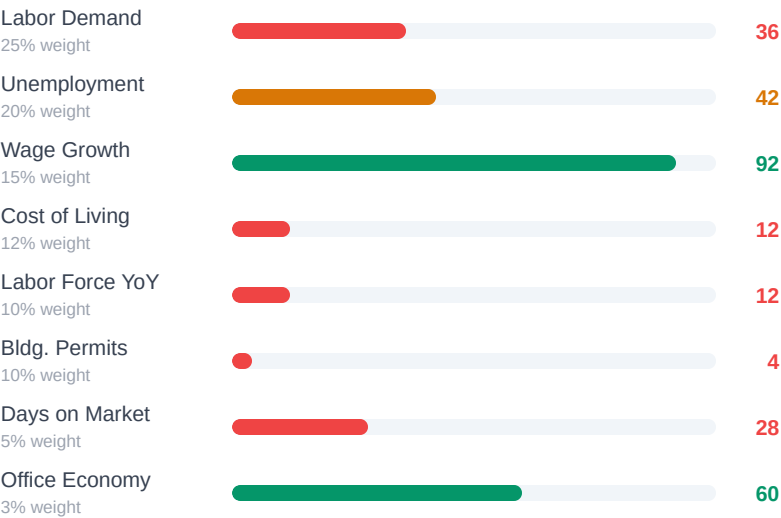
C

VERY POOR

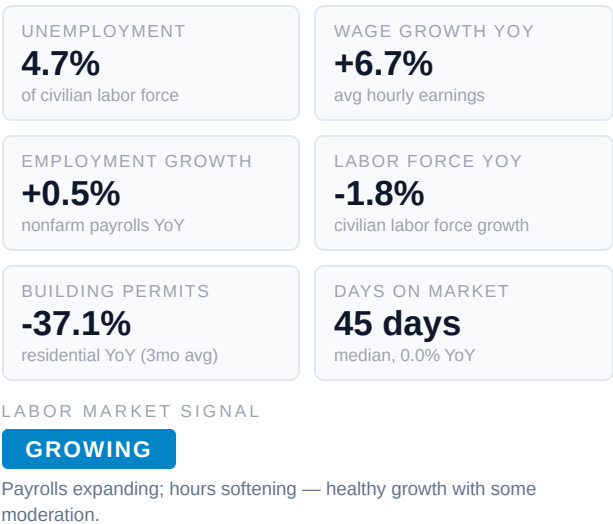
37.5th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and high wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.53, combining a +0.51% employment growth rate and a -0.482% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a +6.72% year-over-year wage growth rate, suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.51% and weekly hours deviation of -0.482% indicate a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend during job growth. This combination suggests a mild contraction in labor demand, rather than a survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 4.53 is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.70% places the market near the median, ranking at the 42nd percentile. This rate suggests a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it neither extremely tight nor overly loose for businesses trying to hire. However, the practical implication is that hiring may not be as competitive as in markets with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.72% is exceptionally high, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers and increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may face higher costs, but workers will have more disposable income, potentially benefiting local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$594/sqft to \$43.84/hr, or 13.55, and a -2.8% year-over-year change in PSF, the city ranks at the 12th percentile in terms of affordability. This low percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could hinder talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by -1.75% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.09%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This significant decrease suggests a potential supply squeeze building ahead, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a 0% year-over-year change. This stable, relatively moderate days on market suggests a balanced market that is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers. However, the lack of change may indicate a normalization of the market rather than a significant shift.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.92, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant operations.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force, which could hinder talent attraction and hiring capacity. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering this location for their business operations. Overall, the city's economic character is complex, with both opportunities and challenges that need to be carefully navigated.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

36.2th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		38
25% weight		
Unemployment		14
20% weight		
Wage Growth		88
15% weight		
Cost of Living		35
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		12
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		26
10% weight		
Days on Market		54
5% weight		
Office Economy		0
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -13.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 63 days median, -4.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its below-average labor demand and high wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.56 and unemployment rate of 5.70% are key metrics defining its current economic character, with the latter indicating a challenging hiring environment. Specifically, the combination of +0.79% employment growth and -0.845% weekly hours deviation signals a labor market with some job growth but hours worked below trend, suggesting a degree of survivor squeeze.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.79% is modest, while the weekly hours deviation of -0.845% indicates hours worked are below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the increase in jobs is not accompanied by an increase in hours worked, suggesting some level of inefficiency or strain in the workforce. The labor demand composite score of 4.56, ranking in the 38th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.70% is relatively high, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that while hiring might be somewhat easier due to the available workforce, the local consumer demand may be weaker compared to areas with lower unemployment rates. For a business trying to hire in this market, the higher unemployment rate could provide a larger pool of potential candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.02% is strong, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This rapid wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as it suggests that employees in the area are seeing significant increases in their earnings. However, for employers, this means a faster increase in labor costs, which could impact profitability.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 9.33, based on \$332/sqft (which is decreasing by -1.2% YoY) compared to \$35.60/hr, Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario ranks in the 35th percentile for affordability. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent without offering wage premiums to offset the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as it indicates a dwindling pool of potential workers. For businesses looking to expand or

establish operations in this area, the shrinking labor force could limit hiring capacity and growth potential.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -13.30%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decrease in building permits suggests that the future affordability of housing in the area may worsen, and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce could be compromised, potentially affecting the attractiveness of the city for both businesses and workers.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.5%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking near the median in terms of days on market, suggests a competitive housing market that could be challenging for relocating workers to find accommodation quickly.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 0.16, ranking in the 0th percentile, indicating a very shallow talent pool in these areas. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but potentially more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements, like logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with strong wage growth indicating a dynamic workforce but also posing challenges for labor costs. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the combination of a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which could severely limit the area's ability to accommodate business growth and attract new talent without significant wage premiums or investment in local development.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

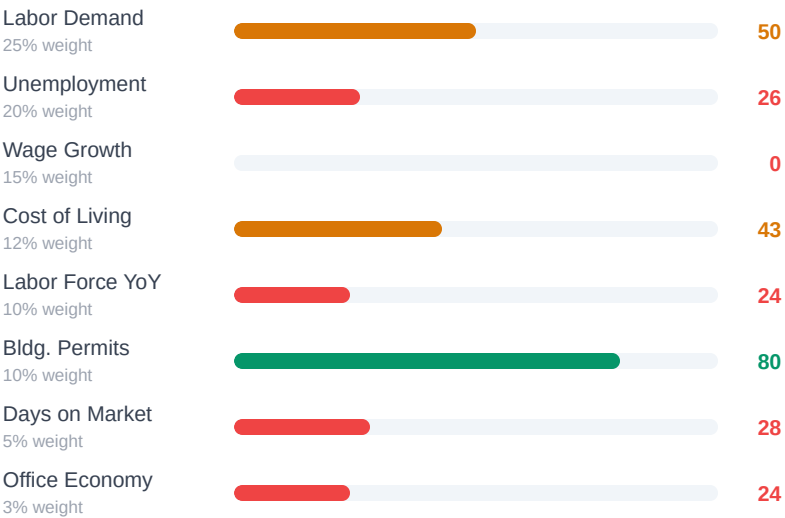
C

VERY POOR

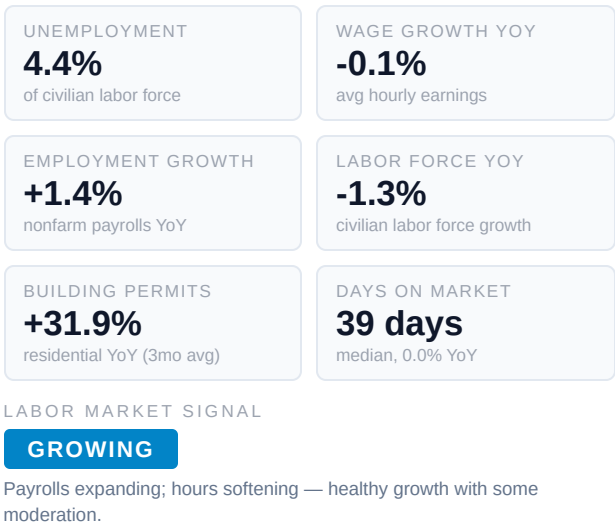
35.4th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of mediocre labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth, at -0.14% year-over-year, and its below-average labor force growth, at -1.32% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 1.36% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.894% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.31, near the median. This combination signals a modest expansion in job growth, but with hours worked below trend, it may indicate some level of survivor squeeze. The labor market is not demonstrating strong, genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.40%, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.14%, ranking at the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth signals flat labor costs for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. The slow wage growth may limit worker purchasing power, potentially affecting local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living ratio of \$208/sqft to \$40.22/hr, with a percentile rank of 43, indicating a near-median affordability level. The city's PSF is falling -1.9% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its affordability. This means the city has a moderate talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at -1.32% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for the declining labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +31.92%, ranking in the top tier. This significant increase in permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. The rising permits suggest developer confidence in the local market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 39 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly. However, the stable days on market may signal a healthy normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city may be better suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a mix of moderate affordability and expanding housing supply, but its stagnant wage growth and contracting labor force pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which may require businesses to adapt their recruitment strategies to succeed in this market.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

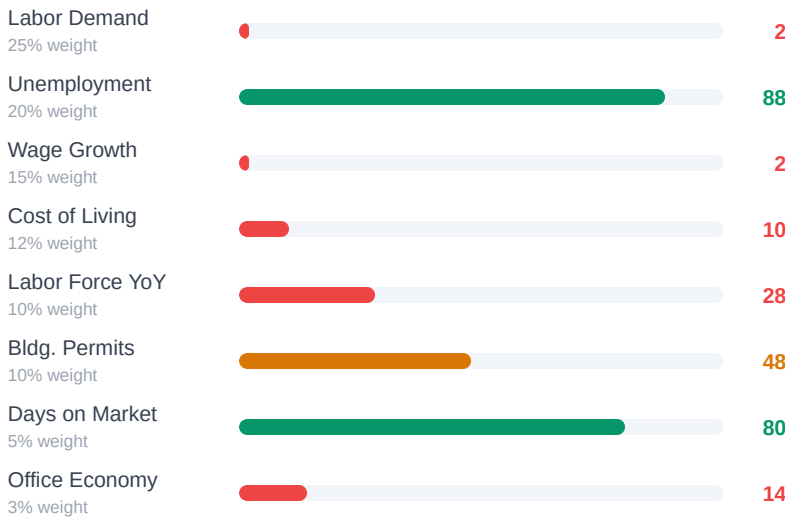
C-

CRITICAL

31.6th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-3.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

51 days
median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.40% ranking it in the top tier. The labor demand and unemployment metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.17% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.446%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. The positive deviation in weekly hours suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking it in the top tier with an 88th percentile score. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also puts upward pressure on wages, making it a competitive market for employers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.09%, ranking it in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. The slow wage growth may make it difficult for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score in the bottom tier, with a 10th percentile rank, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The city's PSF is \$165/sqft, with a ratio of 4.93 to average hourly earnings of \$33.45/hr, and is increasing by 4.4% year-over-year. This makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -0.99% year-over-year, ranking it below average with a 28th percentile score. This decline in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The contracting labor force may limit the city's ability to support business growth and expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is decreasing by 3.15% year-over-year, ranking it near the median with a 48th percentile score. This decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations on workforce accommodation. The decrease in permits may make it difficult for relocating workers to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 51 days, with an 8.5% year-over-year increase, ranking it in the top tier with an 80th percentile score. This slower market means that workers relocating to the city may have an easier time finding a home, as properties are sitting on the market for longer periods. The increasing days on market may signal a normalization of the housing market, making it more accessible to buyers.

Office Economy

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier with a 14th percentile score. The city's office economy is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost environment, but its tight labor market and stagnant wage growth may pose challenges for hiring and expansion. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and contracting labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and attract top talent.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

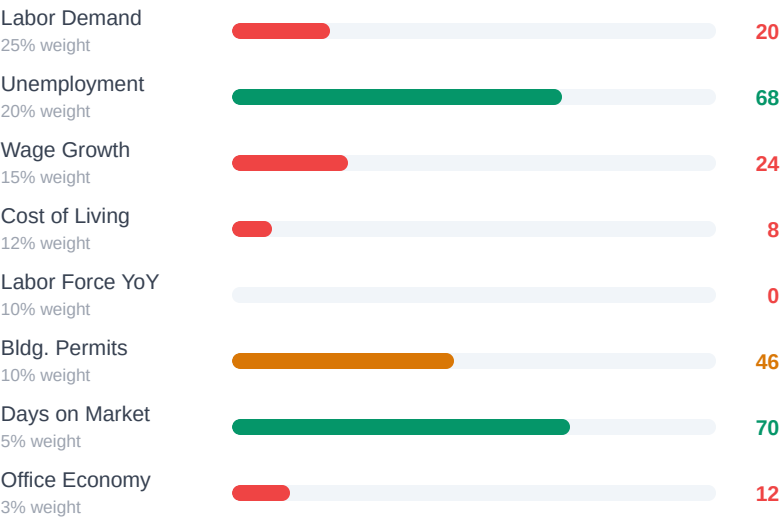
C-

CRITICAL

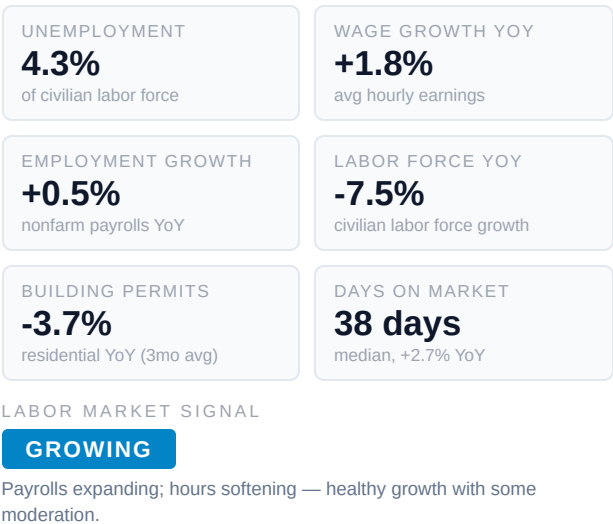
31.6th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 4.11, ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its high cost of living ratio of 6.66, which places it in the 8th percentile for affordability. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.47% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.851% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 4.11 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.30%, ranking it in the 68th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This implies that businesses may have an easier time hiring in this city, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The relatively low unemployment rate suggests that the city is not experiencing extreme labor market tightness.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 1.83%, which is below average and ranks it in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ratio of 6.66, with a PSF of \$217/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.56/hr, ranking it in the 8th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF, with a 2.8% year-over-year increase, further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -7.49% year-over-year, ranking it in the 0th percentile. This significant decline in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire and expand their workforce in the city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -3.73%, ranking it near the median. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 38 days, with a 2.7% year-over-year increase, ranking it in the 70th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively longer period, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also indicate a slower market with less competitive pressure.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is relatively low, ranking it in the 12th percentile. This suggests that the city has a shallower talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional skills, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively slow-growing labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and declining labor force supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which may hinder businesses' ability to expand and hire in the area.

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

30.9th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		8
Unemployment 20% weight		54
Wage Growth 15% weight		32
Cost of Living 12% weight		24
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		32
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		62
Days on Market 5% weight		6
Office Economy 3% weight		22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.5%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +10.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -4.3% YoY 44 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.24 ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its below-average wage growth of +2.49% year-over-year, ranking in the 32nd percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.76% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.415% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion, making it a less attractive location for businesses looking to hire and grow.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, ranking in the near median at the 54th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.49%, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for worker purchasing power, it also means that businesses may face increasing labor costs without corresponding productivity gains.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.94% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and attract the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by 10.33% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is currently 44 days, with a year-over-year decline of -4.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The declining days on market suggests a competitive housing market, which may be a concern for businesses looking to attract talent from outside the area.

Office Economy

Richmond has a professional and office worker share ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, which typically require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Richmond metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses considering relocation or expansion, with some positive signs such as increasing building permits, but also significant challenges like low labor demand and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and competitive housing market, which may make it difficult to attract and retain talent without offering wage premiums.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

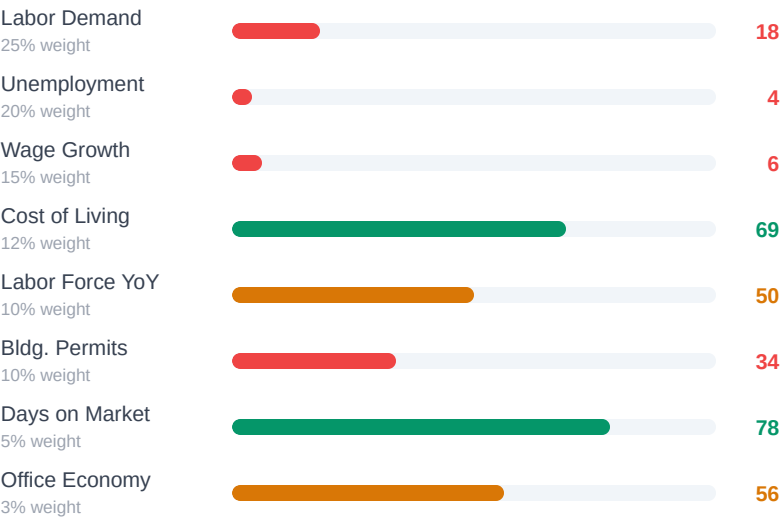
C-

CRITICAL

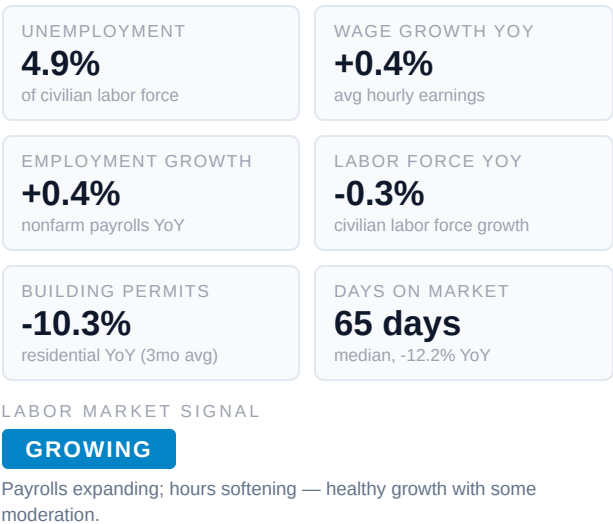
28.5th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 28.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.01 ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 4.90%, which ranks in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is +0.36% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.794% below trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city's labor market experiencing a slowdown. The low labor demand composite score of 4.01 reinforces this signal, suggesting that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with limited slack. This tight market implies that businesses trying to hire in Jacksonville may face challenges in finding qualified candidates, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is +0.39% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also not see a boost in consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score ranking it 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$214/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.81. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year further supports this assessment, making Jacksonville an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is shrinking at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 50th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is

decreasing.

Building Permits

Building permits in Jacksonville are declining at a rate of -10.28% year-over-year, ranking below average at 34th percentile. This decrease in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 65 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.2%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's office economy has a professional worker share ranking it near the median at 56th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office skills, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

In conclusion, Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow wage growth environment, but its low labor demand and tightening housing supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor market slack and shrinking labor force supply, which may hinder hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

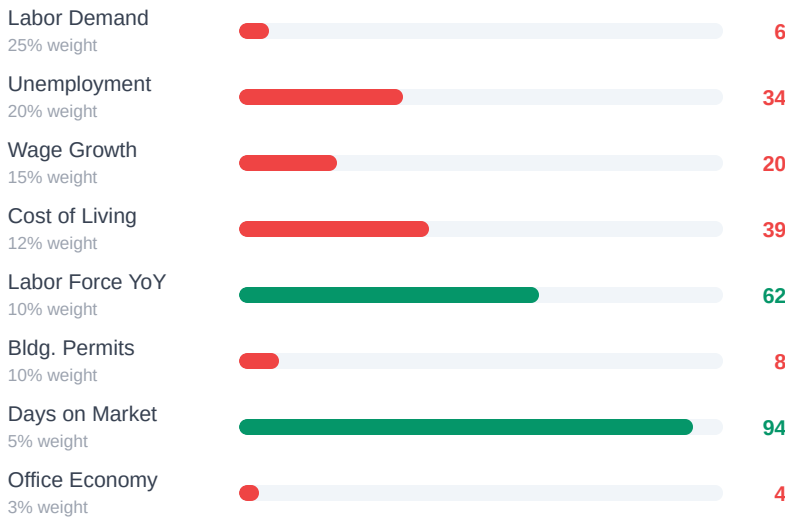
C-

CRITICAL

27.8th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days
median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.99 ranking it in the bottom tier at 6th percentile, and its slow wage growth, at +1.61% year-over-year, ranking it below average at 20th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.07% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.215%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This is a concern for businesses looking to hire, as it may indicate a lack of job creation and a tight labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.80%, ranking it below average at 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, which can make it harder for businesses to hire and may lead to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.61%, ranking it below average at 20th percentile. This slow wage growth indicates a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers may have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking it below average at 39th percentile, with a PSF of \$178/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$31.29/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.69. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that PSF is rising by +0.6% year-over-year may indicate that the city is becoming even less affordable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.25% year-over-year, ranking it above average at 62nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which can make it easier for businesses to hire and find the talent they

need. However, the slow labor demand and low wage growth may offset this advantage.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County is decreasing by -31.66% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at 8th percentile. This signals that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability concerns and make it challenging for workers to relocate to the city. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or other benefits to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Louisville-Jefferson County is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%, ranking it in the top tier at 94th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also signal a weakening demand for housing, which can have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.38, ranking it in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively slow-growing economy with a tight labor market and slow wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and tightening housing supply, which can make it challenging to attract and retain talent. As a result, businesses may need to carefully consider these factors when deciding whether to expand or relocate to the city.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

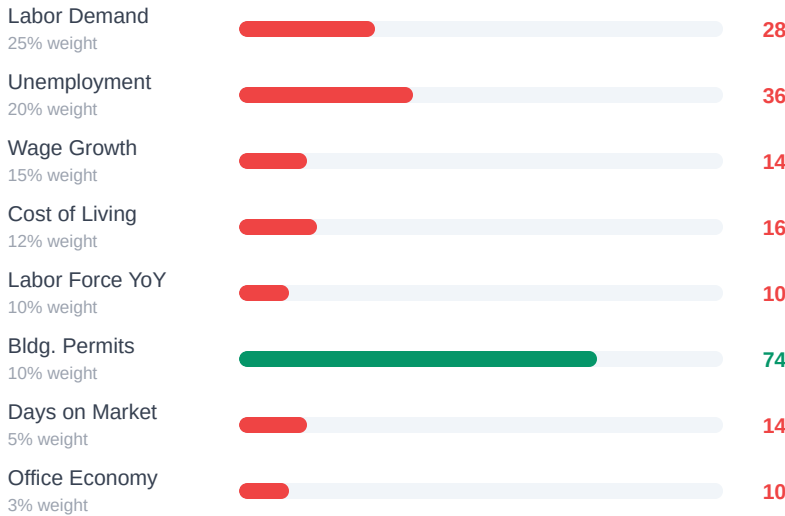
C-

CRITICAL

27.7th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+21.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

50 days

median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.32, and its stagnant wage growth, at +1.05% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.34% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.457% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The hours deviation suggests that even with some job growth, the remaining workers are not seeing an increase in hours, which may indicate a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 5.00%, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.05%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth indicates a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may have limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score that ranks it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, with a PSF of \$339/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.15/hr, resulting in a ratio of 8.89. Although the PSF is falling by -0.9% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent without additional compensation.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.92% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by +21.94% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability may improve, and the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.72, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, making the city less suited for these types of businesses.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor environment, but it also presents significant challenges, including a contracting labor force and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which could hinder hiring and expansion plans, making it essential to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location for business operations.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

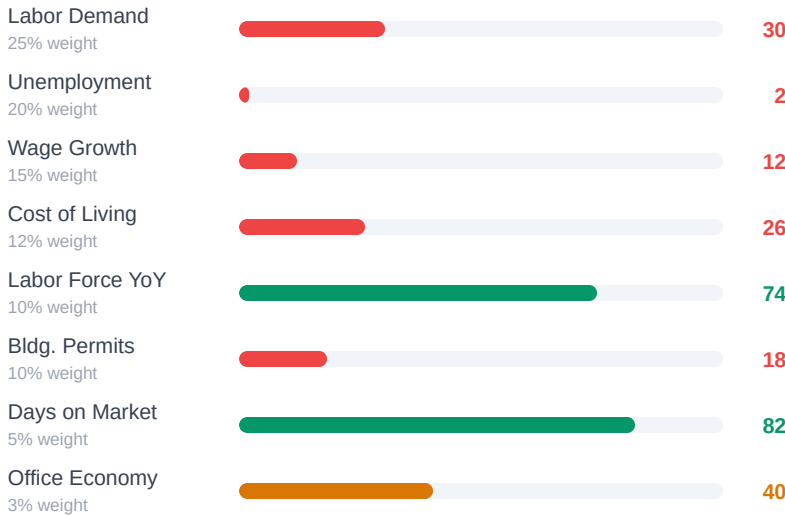
C-

CRITICAL

27.4th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

6.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.7%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 6.00% and its stagnant wage growth of +0.60% year-over-year, which together signal a challenging labor market. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 4.43 and the unemployment rate are the two metrics that most define this city's current economic situation.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.16% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.098% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor demand composite score that is below average at the 30th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand suggests that the city is not adding jobs at a rapid pace.

Unemployment

The actual unemployment rate is 6.00%, which is in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, but the slack in the market could also mean less wage pressure. However, the low unemployment rate relative to the national average suggests that the labor market is more competitive than it seems.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +0.60%, which is in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living score that is below average at the 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.68/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.07. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising +1.6% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability concerns.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, which is above average at the 74th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, which could provide a hiring capacity advantage for businesses locating in the city. The growing labor force suggests that the city has a relatively healthy demographic trend.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -18.71%, which is in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The sharp decline in building permits is a red flag for businesses that rely on a dynamic and growing labor market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%, which puts it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to this city, this could make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests that the local real estate market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy score that is near the median at the 40th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.22 out of 5. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making it suited for businesses that require specialized office skills, but not necessarily a hub for tech, finance, or consulting companies. The city's office economy is neither a major strength nor a weakness, but rather a neutral factor in the location decision.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and stagnant wage growth, which could be both a challenge and an opportunity. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses locating in this city is the tightening housing supply and rising cost of living, which could lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

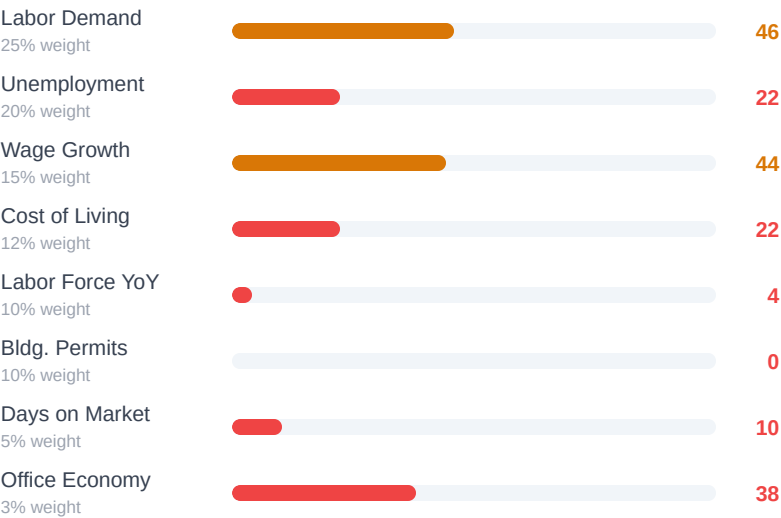
C-

CRITICAL

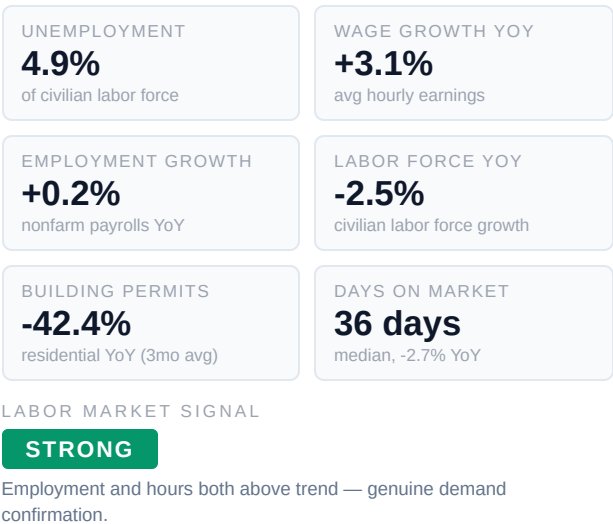
27.2th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor force growth rate of -2.46% YoY and its building permits decline of -42.35% YoY, indicating significant structural headwinds for hiring and future affordability. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.17% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.674% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.21, which ranks near the median at the 46th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one. The modest growth in jobs and hours worked above trend suggests that the labor market is experiencing some level of expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that they may face some competition for talent and potentially rising wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.11%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This represents a moderate pace of wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers and increasing worker purchasing power. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 22nd percentile, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.92. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 3.8% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -2.46% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to mitigate this risk.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has declined by -42.35% YoY, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This sharp decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for existing housing stock and rising costs.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a YoY decline of -2.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The declining days on market suggests that the market is still favoring sellers, making it tough for buyers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin ranks below average at the 38th percentile, with a composite score of 2.22. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city more suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on specialized office or professional roles. The city may be less competitive for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a moderately growing labor market with modest wage growth, but it is constrained by a shrinking labor force, declining building permits, and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth and tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased competition for talent and rising costs.